

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 9 AUGUST 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION

 Matsumoto Castle and its moat, Nagano

THE SPINE · THE LONG WAY ROUND

THE RABBIT HOLE

**The spare-room brewery —
inside home beer making,
where nothing is fast and
none of it is cheaper**

THE GOOD LIFE

**Hoshino's newest ryokan
opens facing the floating torii
— 54 rooms, all sea**

THE GRAND TOUR

**Matsumoto and the old Edo
road you still have to walk on
foot**

Twelve Desks ·
One World

Source: Wikimedia Commons — Matsumoto Castle, Nagano, this weekend's
Grand Tour (p21). Specific subject.

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FROM THE DESK

"There are no shortcuts to any place worth going."

— **Beverly Sills, the American soprano (1929–2007)**¹

A weekend for the long way round. Beer that takes three weeks and never comes out cheaper (p15); a Japanese road you still cross on foot (p21); a weight-loss drug whose shortcut is billed in muscle (p18); the parenting lever that is a slow habit, not a hard lock (p12); a country trying to build in two years the idol industry Korea took twenty to grow (p25). The fast way is on offer everywhere this issue. Almost nothing worth having took it.

THE STRIP — AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	7 AUG
S&P 500	7,757.6
US 10-Year	~4.64%
DXV	99.5
USD/JPY	~157.6
USD/SGD	~1.285
Brent	~\$82
Gold (XAU)	~\$4,348
Bitcoin	~\$64.9k

Levels at the 7 Aug close, unchanged over the weekend; arrows show direction on the week. VWRA (~\$199–201) and a global-aggr proxy firmer. Inflation prints Tuesday — see The Macro Desk (p14).²

THE WEEK AHEAD — WHAT WE ARE WAITING TO BE ABLE TO GRADE

🕒 **TUE 12 AUG — US July CPI.** The single print the whole book turns on: a hot number over a shrinking jobs market is the stagflation box; a soft one opens the door the payrolls report only unlocked (p14).³

🕒 **TUE 12 AUG — Insta360 X6 pre-orders open.** The dual one-inch 360 we flagged as teased last week goes to a real order page; the buy-once verdict still waits on the first independent hands (p9).⁴

🕒 **WK OF 10 AUG — Qwen3.8-Max weights.** Alibaba promised the first open Max-class checkpoint and a 27B

sibling this coming week; a licence line will decide whether "open" means buildable (p7).⁴

🕒 **FRI 14 AUG — Phoebe Bridgers, Lost Weekend.** Critics filed at 91; the user score does not exist until release day, and the gap is the thing to watch (p11).⁵

🕒 **SAT 23 AUG — The National Day Rally.** Where the SG61 "major review" of family support has to become a policy with a number attached (p5).⁶

🕒 **MON 1 SEP — New Upper Changi tender.** The thousand-unit plot that will say whether Berlayar's lone bid was fear or discipline (p6).⁶

SOURCES 1 Beverly Sills (1929–2007), American operatic soprano and arts administrator; the line is widely attributed to her. The issue's throughline — the earned version over the shortcut (see p15, p18, p21). 2 Market strip, ~7 Aug 2026 close (unchanged over the 8–9 Aug weekend): S&P 500 7,757.6 (record), 10Y ~4.64%, DXV ~99.5, USD/JPY ~157.6, USD/SGD ~1.285, Brent ~\$82, gold ~\$4,348 (7-week high), BTC ~\$64.9k; VWRA ~\$199–201 and a global-aggr proxy firmer — CNBC; TradingEconomics; CoinDesk. Not investment advice. 3 US July CPI released 12 Aug 2026 — BLS schedule. 4 Insta360 X6 launch/pre-order 12 Aug; Qwen3.8-Max open weights promised the week of 10 Aug (unshipped at filing) — Imaging Resource; MarkTechPost. 5 *Lost Weekend* (Dead Oceans) out 14 Aug; early Metacritic ~91 — Metacritic. 6 National Day Rally 23 Aug; New Upper Changi Road GLS closes 1 Sep — PMO; URA. Verdicts pending; graded when the check-by passes.

THE WORLD • THE STRAIT

A Corridor With a Price, and Still No Ship

The Hormuz lane finally has a name attached to it: Iran and Oman say they have agreed a "temporary route." Read the small print and it is a toll road built to last two-to-four months, running mostly through Iranian water, that its own author says is not a reopening. The announcement moved the oil price; no hull has moved through it.

A week ago the corridor was a claim without a text; now it is a text without a transit. On 6 August Tehran and Muscat said they had reached an understanding on a "temporary route" through the Strait of Hormuz — a lane active for two to four months, most of it inside Iranian territorial waters, jointly policed with Muscat.¹ The line that matters is the one Tehran itself supplied: the arrangement, Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said, "does not mean the full reopening of the Strait of Hormuz."¹ Iran published a restrictive draft with transit conditions attached, and the oil market jumped on the restrictiveness, not the relief — Brent up about 3.8% to roughly US\$82 on the week.² A metered lane, then, priced and policed by one side, and as of filing not a single verified commercial hull had run it.¹

What is genuinely new is the fee, out in the open at last. Iran frames the charge as covering environment, security and personnel — a service levy split with

Oman, not a cut of cargo — and hangs the whole thing on conditions Washington disputes.² The industry answered over both governments' heads: eight owner and operator bodies, among them the International Chamber of Shipping, BIMCO and the Asian and European shipowners' associations, wrote to warn that a toll on a strait that moves a fifth of the oil shipped by sea "would hurt the interests of European and Asian customers" and hand every other chokepoint a template.³ The corridor exists on paper and in the oil price. It does not yet exist in the water, which is the only place it will count.

2-4

MONTHS THE IRAN-OMAN "TEMPORARY ROUTE" IS MEANT TO RUN — A METERED LANE THROUGH IRANIAN WATERS THAT TEHRAN ITSELF SAYS IS NOT A REOPENING OF THE STRAIT, WITH NO VERIFIED TRANSIT AT FILING.¹

GULF WAR, MONTH 6

A TOLL, NOT A REOPENING

AWAITING A TRANSIT

TEHRAN — IRNA / "SOVEREIGN MANAGEMENT OF AL JAZEERA OUR OWN WATER"

The Iranian framing reads the deal as stewardship, not concession. Gharibabadi tells IRNA the route runs largely through Iran's own waters, jointly managed with Oman, the charge covering environment, security and personnel — and is explicit that it stops short of a full reopening, a two-to-four-month understanding Tehran can extend or end. In this telling the corridor codifies control; the leverage stays home.¹

LONDON — THE SHIPPING LOBBY "A TOLL EVERY CHOKEPOINT WILL COPY"

The industry framing reads past the diplomacy to the invoice. Eight owner and operator groups warn a mandatory Hormuz charge lifts energy costs and tempts copycat levies at Suez and Malacca; the IMO has said there is no mechanism in international law to charge ships for crossing a strait. A fee accepted here, they argue, is a fee demanded everywhere.³

THE SCEPTIC — GRADE IT BY THE WATER, NOT THE WORDING

Everything here is still a claim waiting on a fact, so hold it to facts. The deal is real when three things happen together: the joint text is published, a Western-allied hull runs the lane unmolested, and that first transit is either charged or waved through, settling the fee question. None had at filing. A two-to-four-month understanding, mostly in one country's waters, that its author calls less than a reopening, is a metered ceasefire with a switch — and the constituency profiting from the closure, the grey-market shippers moving sanctioned barrels at a premium, has no reason to want it flipped. Until a ship moves, this is a press release with a price tag.²

SOURCES 1 Iran-Oman "temporary route" understanding, announced 6 Aug 2026 — active 2-4 months, mostly through Iranian territorial waters, jointly managed; Deputy FM Kazem Gharibabadi: the arrangement "does not mean the full reopening of the Strait of Hormuz" — Al Jazeera, 6 Aug 2026; Fortune, 7 Aug 2026 (Iranian-sourced; US disputes elements — HELD; no verified commercial transit at filing). 2 Iran frames the charge as a "service fee" (environment/security/personnel, split with Oman), conditioned on US steps Washington disputes; Brent +~3.8% to ~\$82 on the restrictive draft — CNBC; TradingEconomics; Fortune, 6-7 Aug 2026. 3 Eight owner/operator groups (ICS, BIMCO, Asian Shipowners' Association, European Community Shipowners' Associations et al.) protest a Hormuz fee — "would hurt the interests of European and Asian customers"; IMO — no legal mechanism to charge strait transit — Fortune; Middle East Monitor, 5-6 Aug 2026. Framings attributed; unconfirmed claims single-sourced and flagged.

THE WORLD • TWO FRONTS

The Night the Defence Caught Nothing, and a Deal Signed but Not Started

Over Kyiv, an interceptor shortage turned a barrage lethal and a defence system caught none of the ballistic missiles aimed at it. In Gaza, a disarmament agreement exists on paper and stalls on the ground — Hamas will not begin until Israel withdraws first. Two theatres, one pattern: the promise is signed, the delivery is not.

Ukraine's war now turns on how much of each salvo the defence can knock down, and one night this week it knocked down nothing. In the 5 August barrage on the Kyiv region, the dead numbered at least seventeen, and by CNN's account not one of the Russian ballistic missiles fired that night was shot down.¹ Under the casualties lies a shortage: deliveries of air-defence interceptors are running near a third of last year's pace, and Zelensky named the cause plainly, saying only one ballistic missile was stopped "simply because there are no interceptors for the Patriot system."¹ Two nights later a further strike killed six. Washington, said to have turned down an interceptor request in late July, promised to hurry replacements to Kyiv by pushing back orders owed to other partners — one stockpile drained to top up another.¹

Gaza's story is the same gap in a different form. On 3 August the Board of Peace announced a Hamas disarmament agreement — a weapons-inventory

schedule inside fourteen days, a single Palestinian body to hold arms, an International Stabilisation Force to separate the sides.² Then the floor gave way: Hamas says it will implement no part of it until Israel meets its withdrawal obligations first, and within Israel two cabinet ministers pushed to bar the force altogether.² A framework requiring each side to move first, with neither willing to, is a signature in search of a sequence. Egypt is pushing to accelerate; the deadlock is the news.²

STILL ON THE WIRE

Zero ballistic intercepts — Ukraine stopped none of the ballistic missiles in the 5 Aug Kyiv salvo; interceptor deliveries at ~⅓ of 2025.¹

Signed, not started — Gaza's disarmament deal has a 14-day inventory clock, but Hamas ties any step to an Israeli withdrawal first.²

The US shuffles the queue — missiles rushed to Kyiv by delaying deliveries promised to other allies; the shortage is global.¹

THE FEATURE — THE SHORTAGE BEHIND THE HEADLINES

The connective tissue this week is scarcity of one specific thing: the interceptor. Ukraine's lethal night was not a failure of will but of inventory, and the American fix — pull missiles from one ally's order to plug another's — is the tell that the West is rationing a resource it assumed was elastic. It reframes the war's next phase as an industrial question rather than a political one: not whether allies support Kyiv, but whether the factories can build defensive missiles faster than Russia builds offensive ones. On present numbers they cannot, and every barrage that gets through is the arithmetic of that gap made visible in a Kyiv stairwell.¹

THE SCEPTIC — MIND THE ROUND NUMBERS

Handle all of it with care. "A third of the interceptors" is a figure deployed inside a fight for more of them, not an audited inventory; a leader's casualty count in a war of narratives wants a second source, and the Kyiv toll ran seventeen in most wires and higher in at least one, unreconciled at filing.¹ A disarmament deal that each side reads as obliging the other to move first can be genuine progress or a mutually convenient stall — the text does not say which, and both sides have reasons to call it whichever suits.² Attribute the claims, wait for the delivery, and treat every number here as provisional.

SOURCES 1 Kyiv-region barrage, 5 Aug 2026 — at least 17 killed; CNN reports no Russian ballistic missiles intercepted that night; Zelensky — one ballistic stopped "simply because there are no interceptors for the Patriot system"; 2026 interceptor deliveries ~⅓ of 2025; further strike 6 Aug killed 6; US to delay allied shipments to rush Ukraine after a late-July refusal — Al Jazeera; CNN, 5–6 Aug 2026 (casualty toll unreconciled across wires — HELD). 2 Gaza — Board of Peace announced a Hamas disarmament agreement 3 Aug (14-day weapons-inventory schedule, single arms-holder, International Stabilisation Force); Hamas will not implement until Israel meets withdrawal obligations; two Israeli ministers move to block the ISF; Egypt pushes to accelerate — Times of Israel; Al Jazeera; Chatham House, 31 Jul–4 Aug 2026. Evenhanded; single-source and disputed figures flagged.

SINGAPORE • SG61

The Parade Came Home; the Policy Comes Later

For the first time in a decade the National Day Parade returned to the National Stadium — a covered arena, twice the seats, a first-ever indoor drone show, and a theme, "Go Beyond." What it cost to strip out the Red Lions and the flypast was the parade's own military signature. And the policy the country actually needs still waits a fortnight, for the Rally.

Singapore turned sixty-one on Sunday, and the show came back under a roof. For the first National Day Parade at the National Stadium since 2016 — theme "Majulah Singapura, Go Beyond" — the venue seated roughly forty-two thousand, nearly double a recent Padang edition, and staged the parade's first indoor drone display: more than three hundred craft above the floor, synced with the singer Jasmine Sokko and some two thousand six hundred performers.¹ On the eve, Prime Minister Lawrence Wong's National Day Message set the register — a "more uncertain global backdrop," conflicts spread and trade barriers up, an economy "resilient" but living costs real, and artificial intelligence embraced "on our own terms."² Its one hard announcement was not a number but a promise: a "major review" of how the state supports families, from the cost of raising children to infant and childcare.² A polished birthday, in other words, with the policy held back.

The date that counts is 23 August, when the Rally has to turn that review into something with a figure attached, and the economy hands the leader a tailwind — a 5.7% flash estimate for second-quarter growth, which DBS thinks may revise up toward 5.9%.³ One risk is quite literal: the SIIA has put its 2026 haze outlook at red, a warning it has issued only once before since 2019, with the risk concentrated over the next two months, though the island's air had stayed clear this week.⁴ A confident production, in short, for a country whose real questions — costs, families, the next decade — were deferred to the podium a fortnight on.²

300+

DRONES UNDER THE CLOSED STADIUM ROOF — THE PARADE'S FIRST INDOOR DRONE SHOW, THE HEADLINE OF A HOMECOMING BUILT AROUND THE VENUE'S RETURN RATHER THAN A ROUND-NUMBER ANNIVERSARY.¹

SG61 • GO BEYOND

RALLY: 23 AUG

HAZE WATCH: RED

THE CHATTER — PRIDE, AND THE PRICE OF EVERYTHING

The National Day conversation on the local forums ran, as it does every year, on two tracks beside the parade. The first was the perennial hunt for a free fireworks view without a balloted ticket — the Kallang and Stadium riverside vantage points traded and re-traded, the grumble that a closed ballot leaves most of the island on a bridge. The second, sharper this year, was the cost-of-living undertone: a record-budget indoor spectacle sitting a fortnight before a Message everyone expected to lean on "prices are real," and a "major review" of family support that reads, to the sceptics online, as a headline in search of a Budget line.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — A SPECTACLE IS NOT A POLICY

Two things are doing more work than they can bear. The 5.7% growth print is an advance estimate, year on year off a soft base and led by trade-exposed manufacturing — not evidence a household's costs have turned, and not a figure to bank before the full-year picture firms.³ And the covered-stadium parade, genuinely impressive, bought its comfort by cutting the Red Lions free-fall team, the mobile column and the aircraft flypast for safety and space — the very elements that made the day a display of a nation's hard capabilities rather than a very good concert.¹ The real SG61 story is not Sunday's drones; it is whether the 23 August "review" arrives with money attached. Watch the fortnight, not the fireworks.

SOURCES 1 NDP 2026 at the National Stadium (first since 2016; theme "Majulah Singapura, Go Beyond"; ~42,000 capacity; first indoor drone show, 300+ craft with Jasmine Sokko; ~2,600 performers; Red Lions, mobile column and aerial flypast omitted for safety/venue) — Time Out Singapore; The Online Citizen; Bandwagon. National Day Awards 2026 — ~7,210 recipients across 22 categories (top honourees HELD) — PMO. 2 PM Lawrence Wong's National Day Message, eve of 8 Aug 2026 — "more uncertain global backdrop," economy "resilient," AI "on our own terms," a "major review" of family support (cost of children, infant/childcare) — PMO newsroom; MustShareNews. 3 National Day Rally 23 Aug 2026; Singapore Q2 2026 advance GDP +5.7% y/y (+1.1% q/q), DBS sees a possible upward revision toward +5.9% — SingStat; FXStreet/DBS. 4 SIIA Haze Outlook 2026 rated red (2nd since 2019; Aug–Sep flagged); ASMC Alert Level 2 for the southern ASEAN region 3 Aug; no confirmed elevated SG reading this week (live NEA feed unreachable — HELD) — SIIA; Mothership. 5 Community read — r/singapore National Day threads (free-fireworks vantage points; ballot gripes; cost-of-living undertone), summarised, not fetched live.

PROPERTY • THE TWO SPEEDS

A Record Number of Million-Dollar Flats, in a Falling Market

The headline resale index has now dropped for a second straight quarter — yet over those very months a record 491 public-housing flats sold for seven figures each. Both are true. For an owner weighing when to sell and when to wait, the two-speed market is the only number that matters, and it is not the one on the front page.

Read Singapore's housing market with one number and you will misread it. Public-housing resale prices eased 0.3% in the second quarter, the index down to 202.7 — a second straight quarterly fall, the first back-to-back decline since 2018–19.¹ In those same three months a record 491 resale flats crossed the million-dollar mark, 7.7% of all deals and comfortably past the previous record; the first half of the year logged 902 such sales against 763 a year earlier.¹ A softening average sitting on top of a hardening top end is not a contradiction — it is a market pulling apart at the seams, the prized flats in mature towns still minting records while the composite drifts down on mix.¹ For an owner, that split, not the index, is the read.

What it means in practice is a window, not an alarm. Liquidity at the top end is excellent right now — an unusually good moment to cash a prized resale flat or trade up — while the two down quarters warn against assuming broad capital appreciation from

here.² The private and land markets say the same in their own register: developers are turning selective, the Berlayar Drive state site drawing a lone bid at a record S\$1,515 psf ppr that read as discipline more than conviction, while a well-located launch like River Green sells at nearly nine in ten units.³ The genuine demand test is 1 September, when the thousand-unit New Upper Changi plot closes; a thin field there is the warning, a full one the reassurance.³ Until then, the patient side of the trade is the buy side.²

491

PUBLIC-HOUSING FLATS SOLD ABOVE A MILLION DOLLARS IN A SINGLE QUARTER — A RECORD, PRINTED IN THE SAME THREE MONTHS THE RESALE INDEX FELL FOR A SECOND STRAIGHT TIME. THE TWO-SPEED MARKET IN ONE PAIR OF NUMBERS.¹

TWO-SPEED MARKET

SELL HIGH, BUY PATIENT

1 SEP IS THE TEST

THE CHATTER — RECORD PRICES, FALLING INDEX, ONE FORUM ARGUMENT

On the property boards the argument is how a launch board can sell out while the state land market draws one bid and the HDB index softens two quarters running. The threads split neatly — "2026 will be another year of record HDB prices" posted a scroll above "HDB resale market drastically down again, condo next" — which is the two-speed market rendered as a flame war.⁴ The sober read the regulars reach is the honest one: a metered launch pipeline manufactures its own urgency, prime and large flats keep firming while the composite falls on mix, and the affordability stretch at S\$2,000-plus psf in the outer regions is real. Nobody expects a policy lurch; most expect the government to keep watching.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — A RECORD IS NOT A RALLY

Resist the tidy reading in either direction. A record 491 million-dollar flats inside a falling index is not strength; it is a supply crunch — MOP flats in prime towns, thin and coveted — flattering a market that is broadly cooling, and a headline that sells papers is a poor guide to what a four-room in a heartland town will fetch next year.¹ Equally, one bid at a record land rate is not developers turning bullish; it is a single well-capitalised venture setting a benchmark on a plot others found too tight under the land duties.³ The only number that settles the direction is the 1 September field at New Upper Changi. Until it prints, both the bulls and the bears are quoting the half of the market that suits them. Not investment advice.

SOURCES 1 HDB resale price index Q2 2026 –0.3% to 202.7 (2nd straight fall; first back-to-back since 2018–19); record 491 million-dollar resale flats (7.7% of deals; prev. record 480 in Q3 2025); 1H2026 902 million-\$ deals vs 763 in 1H2025; avg million-\$ price ~S\$1,147,216 — ERA/PropNex Q2 2026 report; EdgeProp SG (figures as reported; verify vs HDB). 2 Read-through for a multi-property owner — top-end liquidity strong, two down quarters caution broad appreciation; patience on the buy side — desk analysis. Not investment advice. 3 Berlayar Drive GLS closed 4 Aug 2026, sole bid S\$576.78m = S\$1,515 psf ppr (record RCR pure-resi rate; ~415 units; analysts expected 4–6 bids); Bayshore Drive (closed 15 Jul) top bid S\$1,323 psf ppr, highest non-CCR GLS rate, URA award expected early-mid Aug; New Upper Changi Road GLS (~1,010 units, MRT-fronting) closes 1 Sep; River Green ~88% sold — EdgeProp SG; URA; CBRE, Jul–Aug 2026. 4 Community read — HardwareZone forums (record-prices-vs-turn threads); r/singapore; summarised, not fetched live. Not investment advice.

TECHNOLOGY · THE OPEN FRONTIER

Meta Ships the Closed One; the Open One Is Still a Week Away

The week's real frontier news came from Meta, which released a coding model and its first agent — powerful, and firmly shut. The open-weights prize everyone actually wants, Alibaba's Max-class Qwen checkpoint, was promised for this coming week and has not landed. The contrast is the story: what ships is closed, and what is open is still a date.

On 5 August Meta's superintelligence lab released Muse Spark 1.2 alongside Muse Code, its first terminal coding agent — a model built for long-horizon software work across large repositories, a million-token context, benchmarked against the top closed labs.¹ It is a genuine capability, and it is entirely proprietary: available only through Meta's API, weights unpublished.¹ The tell is in the pricing. Meta added a "contributor" tier at roughly a twelfth of the standard input rate — cheap access in exchange for permission to train future models on your prompts and completions.¹ That is the closed model's real proposition now: not a model you own, but a discount you pay for with your own data.¹

Set against it is the thing this reader is actually waiting for, and it has not shipped. Alibaba launched Qwen3.8-Max on 3 August as a paid API — a 2.4-trillion-parameter model — and promised to open the Max-class weights, plus a smaller 27B dense

checkpoint, the week of 10 August.² A downloadable Max-tier frontier model would be a real first on the open frontier. But as of this weekend nothing is downloadable, the public repositories are community placeholders only, and the licence terms remain blank — and the licence is the whole question, since a restricted or non-commercial term makes "open" a courtesy, not a right.² The field it is aiming at already shipped: Moonshot's Kimi K3, a 2.8-trillion-parameter model, leads the open pack, DeepSeek's MIT-licensed V4 close behind.³ The only new thing on the open side this week is a date, and dates slip.²

2.4T

PARAMETERS IN QWEN3.8-MAX, WHOSE MAKER HAS PROMISED THE FIRST OPEN MAX-CLASS WEIGHTS THE WEEK OF 10 AUGUST. UNSHIPED AND UNLICENSED AT FILING — A DATE, NOT A DOWNLOAD.²

OPEN FRONTIER

CLOSED SHIPS, OPEN WAITS

READ THE LICENCE

THE CHATTER — THE HOME-LAB CROWD WANTS THE SMALL ONE

On r/LocalLLaMA the anticipation is not for the 2.4-trillion flagship, which no home machine will ever load, but for the dense 27B checkpoint promised beside it — the size that actually fits two consumer cards. The most-upvoted threads are rumour-hunting for the mid-size Qwen variants, not the Max. It captures the split in the open-model world exactly: the headline number is for the leaderboard and the press; the size a person can run at home is the one that changes their Tuesday.²

THE SCEPTIC — "OPEN" IS A LICENCE, NOT A LAUNCH DATE

Two failure modes deserve naming before the weights land. The first is the date: labs announce open releases "next week" and take a month, and until the files are on Hugging Face this is a marketing beat, not a model — Qwen has already let one such date pass.² The second is the term: a Max-class model released under a non-commercial or geography-restricted licence would be open the way a museum is open, look-don't-take. And on the closed side, read Meta's contributor tier for what it is — a data-for-discount trade dressed as a bargain. The open story is real only when the weights download and the licence permits a build. Read the licence line, not the launch tweet.¹

SOURCES ¹ Meta (Superintelligence Labs) released Muse Spark 1.2 + Muse Code (first terminal coding agent), 5 Aug 2026 — long-horizon repo-scale coding, 1M-token context, proprietary (API-only, weights unpublished); standard tier ~\$1.25 in / \$4.25 out per 1M tokens, a "muse-spark-1.2-contributor" tier ~\$0.10 in / \$0.20 out in exchange for training rights on prompts/completions — Yahoo Finance; MarkTechPost, 5 Aug 2026. ² Qwen3.8-Max launched 3 Aug 2026 as a paid API (2.4T-param MoE, multimodal); Alibaba pledged open Max-class weights + a 27B dense checkpoint "the week of 10 Aug"; as of 8 Aug weights unpublished, only community placeholder stubs on Hugging Face, no licence named — MarkTechPost; techsy.io; digitalapplied, 3–7 Aug 2026. ³ Backdrop (weeks old, not this week's delta) — Moonshot Kimi K3 (2.8T) tops the open field on the Artificial Analysis index; DeepSeek V4 (MIT) just behind — Axios; The Register, Jul 2026. "Next week" is a promise, not a release; held facts flagged.

TECHNOLOGY • THE HOME LAB

The Benchmarks Land: What "Runs on a \$300 Card" Actually Means

Last week the claim was that MiniMax's open video model would run on a mid-range GPU. This week the community timed it. The honest answer: it loads, and it generates — a five-second clip in about nine minutes on an RTX 3060. Accessible is real; fast is not. The word to hold onto is "coffee-break."

MiniMax open-sourced H3 — its 33-billion-parameter, omni-modal video model — on 3 August with day-zero ComfyUI support and a knack for turning out footage whose stereo soundtrack is baked in from the first frame.¹ Last week's promise was that the quantised builds would bring it within reach of a mid-range card. This week the community supplied the missing number. On an RTX 3060 with 12GB and a modest host, a five-second clip at 864 by 480, twenty steps, rendered in just under nine minutes end to end — while the lossless "official" recipe still wants two RTX 5090s and a 384-gigabyte host.¹ So the headline holds and dissolves at once: the model genuinely runs on hardware a home-lab reader already owns, and it runs at the pace of a coffee break, not a preview.²

That is the honest shape of the local-video story right now, and it is the buy-once reader's exact wheelhouse — an open, SG-permitted model under

ComfyUI rather than paid-for time on a remote cluster.² The value is in the ownership and the tinkering, not the throughput: the same-week arrival of nodes, templates and community quants is the open ecosystem's real edge over the closed tools, even if the output is slow and the audio fidelity under aggressive quantisation is still unproven.¹ The chip layer was quiet this week — Huawei's Ascend line moves on its own timetable, and no fresh US export action arrived — so the revision is entirely in software: the same weights, compressed until they sit on the desk you already have, and now, finally, timed.³

~9 min

TO RENDER A FIVE-SECOND CLIP ON AN RTX 3060 — THE COMMUNITY'S MEASURED ANSWER TO LAST WEEK'S "RUNS ON A \$300 CARD." IT RUNS; IT DOES NOT RACE.¹

OPEN WEIGHTS • SG-OK

COFFEE-BREAK, NOT REAL-TIME

COMFYUI-NATIVE

THE CHATTER — THE 3060 BENCHMARK THREAD

Within hours of the quants dropping, Hacker News and r/comfyui filled with 3060 benchmark posts, and the framing the crowd settled on was refreshingly unhyped: "not real-time-ish, coffee-break-ish."² The applause is less for H3's benchmark than for the cadence — nodes and templates the day the weights landed, community quants a day later, timings a day after that. That speed of community tooling is becoming the open-video ecosystem's genuine advantage: the moment a capable model ships, the tinkerers have it measured and running on modest hardware before the marketing cycle finishes.¹

THE SCEPTIC — "LOADS" IS NOT "RUNS WELL"

Temper the 3060 headline with the timing it now carries. Nine minutes for five seconds of sub-DVD-resolution video is a demonstration, not a workflow, and the omni-modal audio track's fidelity under Q2 or Q3 quantisation remains unproven — a stereo pass that survives full precision may not survive the squeeze.¹ The honest read is that the quants make the model accessible, not fast or faithful: a fine way to learn the node graph on hardware you own, not a substitute for the VRAM the full weights want. Reserve the verdict for whether the audio holds up at low precision, not whether the workflow opens.²

SOURCES 1 MiniMax H3 (33.1B, omni-modal, behind the Hailuo line) open-sourced 3 Aug 2026 with day-0 ComfyUI support (4 nodes, 6 templates); native stereo audio; community quants (GGUF Q2-Q5, pruned INT4/INT8 -11-12GB, NVFP4) shipped 3-4 Aug; measured RTX 3060 12GB render ~9 min for a 5s 864x480 clip at 20 steps; lossless recipe wants 2x RTX 5090 + 384GiB host — comfyui-wiki; kingy.ai; instasd, 3-4 Aug 2026 (primary pages egress-blocked; via indexed reporting). 2 SG-permitted licence; "not real-time-ish, coffee-break-ish" community framing on Hacker News / r/comfyui — instasd; kingy.ai, summarised. 3 No fresh 5-8 Aug chip delta; Ascend line on schedule, last concrete US move Dec 2025 — TrendForce; Brookings (context, not this week's news). Held facts flagged.

THE KIT · THE PRE-ORDER

The Order Page Opens Tuesday; the Reviews Do Not

Insta360 turns its X6 teaser into a live deposit on 12 August — dual one-inch sensors, 8K, record-the-room-and-crop-later. For a buy-once buyer the sum is simple and unwelcome: the deposit is available days before any verdict is, so the disciplined move is to sit on your hands.

Last week the X6 was a mood reel with a date pencilled in; on 12 August it becomes a page you can actually pay on.¹ The hardware that earns the fuss is the pair of one-inch imagers, a real step up from the smaller units in the X5, wired to a dedicated processing chip, 8K capture, roughly 140 minutes of runtime and a body just under two hundred grams.¹ The idea an owner of the older model already knows is pushed one notch harder: you point the thing once, it swallows the entire scene, and you decide where the picture was pointing back at your desk. For the traveller who wants a single body in the bag rather than a compact and a phone, that is the pitch — and for the first time the sensor behind it is large enough to be taken seriously against a dedicated camera.²

The trouble is that a deposit is not a delivery.³ The date and the marquee numbers are official, but the sticker is still a rumour — the whispers land the base kit near €689 and the loaded bundle near €789 — and not one working unit has reached a tester, because none has left the factory.³ Big imagers stuffed into a twin-lens shell carry their own history of trouble: visible joins where the two halves meet, a

body that runs warm, and a shimmer on quick pans. The buy-once rule points one way — a spherical camera earns the money only if its cropped, flattened frame can stand beside a proper compact, and no reviewer has made that test. Good pitch, unproven object; unless you collect launch-day hardware for sport, sit on the deposit a week.³

1-inch

THE X6'S TWIN SENSORS — THE LARGEST THE 360 LINE HAS FITTED, UP FROM THE X5'S SMALLER PAIR. THE ORDER PAGE OPENS 12 AUG; THE PRICE IS A RUMOUR AND THE REVIEW COUNT IS ZERO.¹

8K · DUAL 1-INCH

DEPOSIT 12 AUG

PRICE STILL A RUMOUR

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sony 1000X THE COLLEXION — the tenth-anniversary flagship this desk met at No. 53 is now on general sale near US\$650; a materials-and-comfort object sharing the XM6's processor. A callback for the buy-and-keep reader, not a new peg.⁴

Samsung Galaxy Glasses — first collections this autumn, price withheld. A first-generation product in every sense: Gemini through the ears only, no display in the lens. Leave it; the version worth owning is a 2027 device.⁴

THE CHATTER — "ONE BODY, OR A FUN SECOND ONE?"

Ahead of Tuesday the camera boards keep returning to a single test: whether a one-inch spherical rig has finally reached the quality to be a trip's only camera rather than a novelty alongside it. The hopeful cite the bigger sensor and the crop-later habit as licence to leave the compact home; the seasoned reply that spherical footage still needs a heavy edit before it becomes a normal photograph, and that a huge headline resolution shrinks a lot once you cut a rectangle out of the globe.² The prevailing mood is wait-and-see — no one is putting money down on a highlight reel.³

THE SCEPTIC — A LAUNCH FILM IS NOT A TEST CHART

Match the excitement to the evidence — today a marketing clip and a leaked number. The specification's finer points are unpublished, and the low-light and underwater case rests on clips the maker hand-picked.³ For someone who buys once and holds on, the bar is plain: the flattened crop has to beat a real compact, and that measurement does not exist yet. Trust the test charts when they arrive, not the launch film — and note, for the record, that this is the X6's pre-order beat, not the Garmin the desk was told to leave alone.¹

SOURCES ¹ Insta360 X6 — official launch/pre-order 12 Aug 2026, 9:00 PDT; dual 1-inch custom Sony sensors, dedicated AI chip, 8K/50fps 360, ~140-min battery, ~195g (delta from No. 66's teaser) — Imaging Resource; RedShark; Geeky Gadgets, ~5–6 Aug 2026. ² The X5 used 1/1.28-inch sensors; spherical stitching/crop tradeoffs — camera press; forums (summarised). ³ Pricing leak-only (~€689 base / €789 Essentials); full spec unpublished; no independent reviews (not shipped) — Geeky Gadgets; RedShark (HELD until 12 Aug). ⁴ Shelf — Sony 1000X THE COLLEXION (10th-anniv flagship, ~US\$649.99, shares the QN3 processor with the XM6; covered No. 53) now on general sale; a callback, not a new peg — Sony Europe press centre; The Tech Outlook. Samsung Galaxy Glasses (Android XR, audio-only, no display; autumn 2026, price unannounced) — Samsung Newsroom; CNBC. Garmin CIRQA not covered, per standing directive. Leaks flagged.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE ESCAPE

A Ryokan That Books the Sea Into Every Room

Hoshino's newest onsen ryokan, KAI Miyajima, opens this summer on the water at Miyajimaguchi — fifty-four rooms, every one facing the sea, looking across to the floating torii of Itsukushima. After the Nara prison stay we flagged last week, this is the escape without the provocation: no concept to argue with, just the tide and the gate.

Where last week's Hoshino flagship dared you to sleep in a converted Meiji prison, this one asks nothing but that you watch the water.¹ KAI Miyajima opens this summer at Miyajimaguchi, on the Hiroshima shore directly across the strait from the Itsukushima Shrine and its great floating torii — fifty-four rooms that all look out on the water, among them the signature "Umigiri," or Sea Fog, suites themed on the Setouchi mist, a public hot spring and a Setouchi Ancient Sauna.¹ It is the KAI brand reaching for one of the country's most-shot panoramas, and its pitch inverts the prison's — not a provocation to reckon with but a room built entirely around a tide and a gate.¹ The catch, and it is the honest one, is that you cannot yet book it: the nightly rate is unpublished and the exact opening date within "summer" is unconfirmed at filing.²

Which makes the more useful advice the escape you can actually take this month.² Two Hoshino houses are open now: KAI Kusatsu, opened 7 June in Gunma with a private-tunnel approach to its onsen, and — the neat coincidence with this weekend's Grand Tour

— KAI Matsumoto, reopened 4 August after renovation, a hot-spring base a short hop from the black castle and the Kiso road the Travel Desk walks overleaf.³ If the escape is a sound rather than a view, the object worth the money is Sennheiser's Momentum 5 Wireless at about US\$400, whose user-replaceable battery is the buy-once detail its rivals refuse.⁴

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ROOMS AT KAI MIYAJIMA, ALL OF THEM TURNED TO THE WATER AND THE TORII ACROSS THE STRAIT — A RYOKAN BUILT AROUND A SINGLE VIEW. RATE AND EXACT OPENING DATE UNPUBLISHED AT FILING.¹

KAI'S TORII-VIEW HOUSE

OPENS SUMMER 2026

BOOK KUSATSU / MATSUMOTO NOW

BOOKABLE THIS SEASON

KAI Kusatsu — opened 7 Jun in Gunma; a private tunnel to the onsen, in one of the great hot-spring towns. Open and taking reservations.³

KAI Matsumoto — reopened 4 Aug; a Shinshu base beside the castle and the Kiso Valley the Grand Tour covers (p21). The escape and the trip in one booking.³

THE CHATTER — THE TORII-VIEW ROOMS DID THE PRE-SELLING

The trade coverage fixed, predictably, on the sea-facing rooms and the Umigiri concept — waking to the Setouchi mist with the floating gate across the water, the single image doing all the work in the previews.¹ The practical caution this desk shares: excitement for a property you can look at but not yet reserve is a mood board, not a plan — and the view and the onsen ritual are both available at Kusatsu and Matsumoto today while Miyajima finishes opening.³

THE SCEPTIC — AN ASPIRATION IS NOT AN ITINERARY

Be honest about what can and cannot be acted on. KAI Miyajima is a lovely idea and, right now, only an idea: no published rate, no confirmed date, no booking page — a thing to anticipate, not a trip to plan, so a reader who wants a Japanese onsen escape this summer should be steered to the two KAI houses already open.² A beautiful render and a "summer 2026" line are not a reservation, and the KAI tier, while excellent, prices in the tens of thousands of yen a head — worth it for the ritual, not because a new opening is automatically the one to chase. Not an endorsement.¹

SOURCES ¹ KAI Miyajima (Hoshino Resorts) — new onsen ryokan opening summer 2026 at Miyajimaguchi, Hiroshima, across the strait from the Itsukushima Shrine torii; 54 sea-facing rooms; "Umigiri" (Sea Fog) rooms; public hot spring + Setouchi Ancient Sauna — Hoshino Resorts news & press center; MICE Times, 2025–26. ² Nightly rate and exact opening date unpublished at filing (KAI typically ~¥30–50k pp/night — HELD) — Hoshino Resorts. ³ Bookable now — KAI Kusatsu opened 7 Jun 2026 (Gunma; private-tunnel onsen approach); KAI Matsumoto reopened 4 Aug 2026 after renovation (Shinshu; cross-ref the Grand Tour, p21) — Hoshino Resorts press center. Continuity: this desk covered HOSHINOYA Nara Prison at No. 66 (the flagship "prison hotel") — a distinct property. ⁴ Sennheiser Momentum 5 Wireless — shipped 16 Jun 2026, US\$399.99; user-replaceable battery, aptX Lossless, 8-mic ANC — Sennheiser newsroom; SoundGuys. Not an endorsement; unverifiable figures held.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE HOLD

Spider-Man Holds — and We Owe You a Correction

The reboot dropped about 60% in weekend two and still posted one of the biggest second weekends ever. But the record we printed last week was wrong: the opening was the second-biggest domestic ever, not the first. We keep score on ourselves, so here is the fix — and, on Friday, Phoebe Bridgers.

First, the correction, because a magazine that grades its predictions has to grade its facts. Last week's book called *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*'s opening "the largest domestic ever." It was not: verified trade reporting puts the opening at about US\$355 million — the second-biggest domestic debut ever, behind one film, and US\$927 million worldwide, the second-highest global bow.¹ Historic, in other words, but not the record we awarded it. Setting that straight, the second weekend was genuinely strong: down roughly 60% to about US\$143 million, which projects as one of the three biggest second weekends in history, carrying the domestic total past US\$650 million and the worldwide figure beyond US\$1.2 billion.¹ The reception is the real story — 91% with critics, a rare 98% with audiences, tying the highest crowd score any Marvel film has drawn.²

Read the gap between those two numbers. A nine-point spread between a good-not-great critical score and an ecstatic audience one says the film is landing harder with fans than reviewers — the melancholy, street-level tone a homecoming for the audience and

merely a solid entry for critics, whose 91% falls outside the franchise's top ten.² The week's other event is Friday's: Phoebe Bridgers' *Lost Weekend* arrives on 14 August under a Metacritic of about 91, dedicated to her late father. The number that does not exist yet is the users' one, which lands only on release — and that critic-versus-crowd gap is the metric to watch, here as at the box office.³

A nine-point gap between critics and crowd is the whole story: the film is a homecoming for fans and a solid entry for reviewers.

CORRECTED: 2ND-BIGGEST, NOT 1ST

98% AUDIENCE

BRIDGERS · 14 AUG

ON THE HORIZON

Nolan's *The Odyssey* — holding strong in the top tier through the Spider-Man wave; the counter-programming that refuses to fade.⁴

***Lost Weekend* user score** — nonexistent until Friday; the release-day gap versus the critics' 91 is the thing to watch.³

THE CHATTER — THE TRAILER THAT EVERYONE WATCHED

The fan conversation around *Brand New Day* is unusually warm for a reboot, and the numbers back the mood: the first trailer became the most-viewed ever at around 1.1 billion views, and the boards read the "depressed Spider-Man," small-stakes tone as a deliberate rebirth after years of multiverse spectacle.² Whether the 98% is the film or the relief at a smaller story is the open question — and, as with the album on Friday, the durable verdict is the repeat-view one, not the opening rush.²

THE SCEPTIC — THE CROWD SCORE IS DOING THE LIFTING

Read the 98% against the 91% and the caution follows. On the critics' side the film sits outside Marvel's top-ten scores — mid-pack for the franchise, not a landmark — and the ecstatic audience number is carrying the "historic" framing that the reviews do not support.² Opening-weekend audience scores are the least durable data in the business, filed on a first watch by the most motivated fans; the honest verdict is the four-week one. The same discipline applies to Friday's album — a Metacritic of 91 under embargo is a first impression, not a settled record.³

SOURCES 1 CORRECTION to No. 66: *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* opening —US\$355M domestic (second-biggest ever, not first) / ~US\$927M worldwide (second-highest global debut) — The Hollywood Reporter; CNN, 2 Aug 2026. Second weekend (8–10 Aug) ~US\$143M (~60%); domestic past ~US\$653M, worldwide past ~US\$1.2B; among the top three second weekends ever — Deadline; Variety; Forbes, 7 Aug 2026 (Sunday estimates). 2 Rotten Tomatoes 91% critics / 98% audience (ties the highest MCU audience score); the 91% falls outside the MCU's top-10 critic scores (Paul Tassi, Forbes); first trailer ~1.1B views — ComicBasics; Forbes, Aug 2026. 3 Phoebe Bridgers, *Lost Weekend* (Dead Oceans), out 14 Aug 2026; early Metacritic ~91 ("universal acclaim," 7 critics); dedicated to her late father; guests incl. Alex G, Jack Antonoff, Julien Baker, Lucy Dacus; no user score until release (HELD) — Metacritic; Billboard; AP, 8 Aug 2026. 4 *The Odyssey* (Nolan) holding in the top tier — Rotten Tomatoes editorial, Aug 2026. Critic scores are first impressions; user-vs-critic gaps flagged.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE EVIDENCE

What You Know Beats What You Block

A 2026 study finds that a parent's open awareness of what a child does online curbs bedtime screen use more reliably than any parental-control app. The lever, again, is not a lock on the device — it is a relationship with the child using it. General guidance, not medical advice.

The year's parenting debate has been about barriers — age-gates, phone-free schools, outright bans. A 2026 study reframes the lever. Looking at what actually curbs children's bedtime screen use, researchers found that parental *knowledge* — an open, non-adversarial awareness of what a child is doing online — outperformed parental-control apps at reducing problematic late-night use.¹ It extends a thread this desk tracked last week, that media-parenting practices beat blanket bans, and sharpens it into the window that matters most for an eleven-year-old: the hour before sleep.¹ The finding sits alongside a quieter institutional shift — earlier this year the American Academy of Pediatrics retired its rigid hourly screen-time limits for a "bigger-picture" model built on content, context and the parent-child relationship rather than a stopwatch.²

That is a genuine revision of the default advice, and a freeing one. The control app promises a lock; the

evidence says the durable lever is a conversation — a child who knows their parent knows, without a fight, moderates in a way the blocked child, resentful and resourceful, does not.¹ For a parent at the threshold of a daughter's own device, the implication is unglamorous: the most effective tool is not bought from an app store but built at the dinner table, in the ordinary habit of asking and listening. Monitoring software still has a place at the margins; the study's point is that it is a supplement to the relationship, not a substitute for it — and that the households treating it as the main event are optimising the wrong variable.³

Knowing

- A PARENT'S OPEN AWARENESS OF A CHILD'S ONLINE LIFE
- CURBED BEDTIME SCREEN USE MORE RELIABLY THAN A CONTROL APP IN THE 2026 STUDY. THE LEVER IS THE RELATIONSHIP, NOT THE LOCK.¹

KNOW, DON'T JUST BLOCK

THE BEDTIME WINDOW

GENERAL GUIDANCE

THE CHATTER — FROM "HOW MANY MINUTES" TO "WHAT DO YOU KNOW"

Among paediatric and parenting researchers the centre of gravity has moved over the past year from the daily-minutes number to the questions of content, timing and the parent's own knowledge. The 2026 finding fits that turn: a household's screen culture, and specifically what the parent genuinely knows about the child's online day, does more than any minute-counting dashboard.³ The practical read circulating in those circles is not a new app but an old skill — the low-drama, high-frequency conversation, which the software market cannot sell and therefore rarely mentions.³

THE SCEPTIC — KNOWING IS A CORRELATION, NOT A SWITCH

Read the strength of the claim precisely. This is observational research — parental knowledge correlates with, and appears to precede, less problematic use — but it is not a randomised trial, and the effect sizes in this literature are typically modest, not transformative.¹ A parent who knows a lot about their child's online life may differ in a dozen other ways the model can't fully strip out. The honest takeaway is not "know everything and the problem is solved"; it is "of the levers in your control, an open relationship is the best-supported and the cheapest, and a control app is a weak substitute for it." A reason to talk, not to panic — and not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 2026 study — parental *knowledge* (open awareness of a child's online activity) outperformed parental-control apps at curbing children's bedtime/problematic screen use — ScienceDirect, 2026 (effect sizes not independently retrieved this session — HELD; cite the finding, not a coefficient); continuity with No. 66's "media-parenting beats bans" thread and the ABCD cohort work. 2 American Academy of Pediatrics retired rigid hourly screen limits (Jan 2026) for a content/context/relationship model — The Conversation, 2026. 3 Field shift from daily-minutes to content/timing/knowledge framing — paediatric and parenting-research consensus, summarised. Observational, not a randomised trial; effect sizes modest. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE FAMILY DESK • SINGAPORE & THE PANIC

The School Locked the Phones; the Evidence Says Don't Overreact

Singapore's schools now store phones the entire school day and moved the government tablet's bedtime earlier — policy moving faster than most countries. Set beside it, the researchers who keep warning the alarm is oversized. Two truths a parent has to hold at once. Not medical advice.

Singapore has moved further than most. Since January, enhanced Ministry of Education measures store students' phones and smartwatches for the entire school day — recess and co-curricular activities included — and the default "sleep hours" on government student devices were pushed earlier, from eleven to half-past ten.¹ The backdrop is a large 2026 correlational study linking four-plus hours of daily screen use to higher anxiety, depression and conduct problems — an effect running substantially through disrupted sleep and reduced activity, which is why the lock and the earlier curfew aim at the mechanisms, not the minutes.² On the current evidence the single most defensible boundary a parent can set is the one the policy targets: guard the wind-down.²

And yet the desk's standing job is the contrarian note, because the loudest researchers on this beat urge calm. Candice Odgers and Andrew Przybylski have argued for years that the screen-and-wellbeing correlation is small and inconsistent — Przybylski's line puts it "about the size of the correlation between wearing glasses and well-being" — and Odgers

stresses reverse causation: already-struggling children go online more, rather than screens causing the distress.³ Both are true at once: the policy is a reasonable, low-cost hedge on the mechanisms; the panic that treats every hour of screen as damage is not what the best evidence supports.³

10:30

THE NEW DEFAULT DEVICE "BEDTIME" ON SINGAPORE'S GOVERNMENT STUDENT TABLETS, PULLED EARLIER FROM ELEVEN — POLICY AIMED AT THE SLEEP MECHANISM THE 2026 EVIDENCE KEEPS POINTING TO, NOT AT THE RAW MINUTES.¹

SG LOCKS THE SCHOOL DAY

GUARD THE WIND-DOWN

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

WHAT THE EVIDENCE ACTUALLY SUPPORTS

Know it — awareness of the child's online life beats a control app; ask before you audit (p12).⁴

Guard the last hour — a screen-free wind-down beats a rigid daytime minutes cap.²

Mind the mechanism — most of the harm runs through lost sleep and activity; protect those.²

Skip the panic — the correlation is modest and contested; a calm evening video is not a wound.³

THE CHATTER — A POLICY AHEAD OF MOST, A HOUSEHOLD BEHIND IT

The Singapore parent conversation splits on the school-day lock: relief that the fight over phones in class is settled, worry that it merely displaces the use home, where a survey has teens averaging some eight and a half hours a day.¹ The displacement worry lands back on the two evidence-backed levers — the relationship and the wind-down — because a school can lock a locker but only a household can guard a bedtime.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — DON'T BE ALARMIST ABOUT THE NUMBER

Keep the contrarian note the desk always carries. The four-hours-and-worse figure is correlational, and the calm researchers are right that a chunk of it is reverse causation — distressed children reaching for screens, not screens manufacturing the distress.³ The failure mode is a parent who reads the policy as a mandate for a rigid, anxious blackout that turns every evening into a fight, which helps no one's sleep. The evidence supports a gentle, consistent last-hour habit and an open relationship — not a stopwatch and not a siege. Protect the wind-down, keep talking, and manage the daytime minutes roughly. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES ¹ Singapore MOE enhanced screen-use measures in force from Jan 2026 — phones/smartwatches stored the entire school day (incl. recess/CCAs); government student-device default "sleep hours" moved 11pm → 10:30pm; teen device-use survey ~8.5 hrs/day (as reported) — MOE press release (30 Nov 2025); CNA/IPS coverage (secondary — HELD on the exact survey figure). ² 2026 study — ≥4 hrs/day screens linked to higher anxiety (+~45%), depression (+~61%), conduct problems (+~24%), mediated substantially by disrupted sleep and reduced activity (n=50,231, ages 6–17) — *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications*, Jan 2026 (as reported; correlational). ³ Candice Odgers (UC Irvine) and Andrew Przybylski (Oxford) — the screen-wellbeing correlation is small/inconsistent ("about the size of the correlation between wearing glasses and well-being"); reverse causation — NPR, Jun 2026; UCLA. ⁴ Continuity with p12 (knowledge over control apps). Correlational; effect sizes modest. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK • THE SETUP

The Whole Book Waits on Tuesday

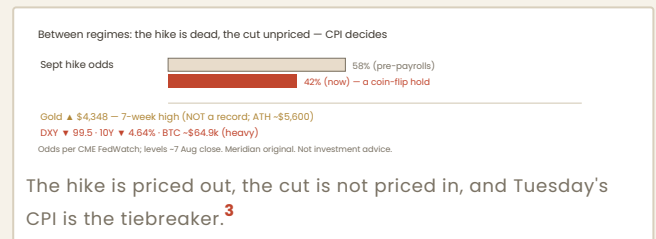
A week after payrolls went negative, the repricing has settled into a coin-flip: the market has killed the rate hike but not yet bought a cut. Everything now hinges on Tuesday's inflation print. A hot number over a cracking jobs market is the stagflation box; a soft one opens the door. And a correction to last week's book: gold's move was a seven-week high, not a record.

SEPT HIKE ODDS ~42%	GOLD \$4,348	US 10Y ~4.64%	DXY 99.5	CPI Tue
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Start with the correction, because the honesty rule outranks the narrative. Last week's book called gold's push to about US\$4,348 "a record." It was not: that was a seven-week high, and gold's strongest week since the winter, but the all-time high — near US\$5,600 earlier this year, before a ~30% drawdown — still stands.¹ With that fixed, the picture is a market between regimes. July's negative payrolls print, revised down by 103,000 across the prior two months, detonated the hawkish "maybe a hike" story three Fed dissenters had wanted.² But the repricing stopped halfway: the September hike odds collapsed from around 58% to roughly 42% — not a cut, a coin-flip *hold*. The market took the hike off the table and declined, so far, to put a cut on it.²

Everything now points at Tuesday. The 12 August inflation print is the hinge: a hot number over a labour market that just contracted is the stagflation box and revives the buried hike talk; a soft one opens

the door to eventual cuts.³ Follow the chain the market half-ran: jobs contract, the dollar slips to a two-week low and the ten-year eases to about 4.64%, but sticky 3.2% wages and a live Hormuz oil bid keep the inflation tail alive — so the relief went into gold and record equities while bonds got only modest relief and bitcoin stayed heavy near US\$65,000.⁴ Name the regime and you name the risk: dovish-relief-without-a-cut, dollar-off, with a stagflation trapdoor Tuesday could open.³



DOVISH, NOT YET EASING **DOLLAR OFF**
CPI IS THE HINGE

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Read the four as one system. Global equities ride the dovish relief to records, but their earnings now lean on a labour market that just contracted, and for a Singapore holder the softer dollar trims unhedged returns even as the index climbs. Global bonds got a small tailwind from falling yields, capped by the inflation tail. Gold is the regime's winner — a rate-relief trade and an inflation hedge at once, which is how it prints a seven-week high while equities also set records — but stretched. Bitcoin is the odd one out: a softer dollar should help, yet a ~4.6% real-yield opportunity cost has it pinned near US\$65,000, a lagging risk asset, not a haven. The tiebreaker for all four is Tuesday's print. Not advice.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — THE MOST OVERBOUGHT TAPE IN FORTY YEARS

Not everyone is buying gold at these levels. BofA's Paul Ciana flagged "risk of correction elevated," citing the most overbought monthly reading on gold since 1980 — the chase into US\$4,348 is buying the most stretched tape in four decades, however good the macro logic.⁵ The deeper hazard is the box the Fed is in: a hot Tuesday print over a contracting jobs market is stagflation, and reprices the equity records and the "cuts are coming" trade at once. A market setting records on the worst jobs number of the year is betting the cut arrives before the recession — a bet it has lost before. Market education, not advice.³

SOURCES 1 CORRECTION to No. 66: gold's ~US\$4,348 was a seven-week high and its best week in ~7 months, NOT an all-time record; the ATH (~US\$5,600, earlier 2026) followed by a ~30% drawdown still stands — TheStreet/BofA; CryptoRank, 7 Aug 2026. 2 US July payrolls -23,000 (first contraction since Feb; -103k May-June revisions; unemployment 4.1%, a shrinking-labour-force quirk; wages +3.2%); Fed held 3.50-3.75% with 3 dissents wanting a hike; September hike odds ~58% → ~42% post-payrolls (CME FedWatch) — CNBC; CBS; HousingWire, 7 Aug 2026. 3 US July CPI due 12 Aug 2026 — the hinge between a revived hike (stagflation) and eventual cuts — BLS; Benzinga. 4 ~7 Aug close: S&P 500 7,757.6 (record), 10Y ~4.64%, DXY ~99.5 (2-wk low), USD/JPY ~157.6, Brent ~\$82, gold ~\$4,348 (+7.5% wk), BTC ~\$64.9k; VWRA ~\$199-201, global-aggr proxy firmer (HELD exact) — CoinDesk; TradingEconomics. 5 Paul Ciana (BofA) — "risk of correction elevated" on gold; most overbought monthly RSI since 1980 — Yahoo Finance/BofA, Aug 2026. Market explanation and education, NOT investment advice; forecasts flagged; unverifiable levels held.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE INVITATION

The Spare-Room Brewery

Four ingredients, three weeks of patience, and a shed full of stainless steel: home beer making is the hobby that turns a kitchen into a small factory and never, honestly, saves anyone money. It is also a hobby in retreat — its flagship club has halved since 2019 — which makes now a good time to look at what the diehards actually do down there.

Beer is four things — water, malted grain, hops, yeast — and the whole craft is coaxing sugar out of the grain into a sweet liquid called wort, boiling it with hops, and letting yeast turn it into alcohol over a couple of weeks.¹ There are three roads in. Extract skips the grain and uses factory-made malt syrup — a pot and a bucket, hardest to ruin, the near-universal on-ramp. All-grain does the sugar extraction yourself, mashing crushed grain in hot water for an hour: full control, more gear, more discipline. And brew-in-a-bag is all-grain's shortcut, the grain in a mesh bag in one kettle — which is exactly what every modern electric all-in-one automates.¹ The gateway is the same for everyone: the first time you drink a beer you made and it is genuinely good, the alchemy dissolves, and the founding mantra — Charlie Papazian's "relax, don't worry, have a homebrew" — starts to make sense.²

The honest scale of the world is a story of contraction, and it belongs at the front. The communities are still vast — the main subreddit runs to roughly 1.2 million members, the HomeBrewTalk forum past a million registered users and twenty-five years of archives — but the American Homebrewers Association, the hobby's institution, has fallen from a 2019 peak near 46,000 members to about 23,000, a

halving in five years, and in early 2025 it split from its parent body and put its national convention on hiatus.³ Craft beer, the culture it rode, is down about 4% by volume two years running.³ The pandemic gave home brewing a last surge; it has aged and thinned since. What follows is the deep end of a hobby past its peak — where the diehards gather, what they buy, and the tropical problem a Singapore brewer has to solve before anything else.⁴

46k → 23k

AMERICAN HOMEBREWERS ASSOCIATION MEMBERSHIP, 2019 TO 2025 — A HALVING IN FIVE YEARS, AND THE NUMBER THAT FRAMES THE WHOLE HOBBY: RICH IN COMMUNITY, PAST ITS CULTURAL PEAK.³

EXTRACT • ALL-GRAIN • BIAB

A HOBBY IN RETREAT

NEVER ACTUALLY CHEAPER

THE GATEWAY — HOW PEOPLE FALL IN

The first good pint — you drink something you made, it is genuinely good, and the mystery evaporates; the four-ingredient simplicity does the rest.²

The control itch — extract feels like assembly; all-grain feels like cooking, and the jump from following a recipe to writing one is the hook.¹

The gear rabbit hole — the kettle is never the last purchase; there is always a better fermenter, a colder chamber, a keg to fill.⁵

THE INVITATION — WHO DOES THIS, AND WHY

The demographic is a tinkerer's: home cooks who want more control, ex-craft-beer obsessives, engineers who like a process with dials, and a thick cohort of middle-aged men with a garage or a spare corner and time on a weekend.⁴ The draw is three things at once — a craft you can taste, a process you can optimise endlessly, and a forgiving chemistry that rewards patience over money. It is cooking that takes three weeks to plate and a factory you assemble one stainless vessel at a time. Nobody does it to save money; the going, as with every rabbit hole, is the point.⁵

SOURCES 1 Homebrewing basics — water/malt/hops/yeast; extract vs all-grain vs brew-in-a-bag (BIAB); modern electric all-in-ones automate eBIAB — Brew Your Own; Beer Maverick; AHA tutorials, 2026. 2 The "gateway" first-good-batch moment; Charlie Papazian's "Relax, don't worry, have a homebrew" (RDWHAHB), *The Complete Joy of Homebrewing* (1984) — Smithsonian. 3 r/Homebrewing ~1.2M members (GummySearch, Jun 2026); HomeBrewTalk 1M+ registered users; AHA membership ~46,000 (2019 peak) → ~23,000 (early 2025), incorporated independently Jan 2025, Homebrew Con on hiatus; US craft-beer volume ~4% in 2024 and again ~4% in 2025 — Forbes; Wine Enthusiast; Beervana; Brewers Association, 2025–26. 4 Demographic and draw — r/Homebrewing; HomeBrewTalk; community, summarised. 5 The upgrade-itch/build-craft framing — community build threads, summarised.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE COMMUNITY & THE GEAR

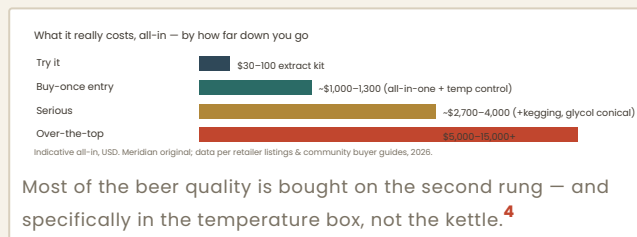
Where They Argue, and What They Buy

The forums have one running fight — whether the sacred rules survive a blind taste test — and a house sceptic, Brülosophy, that keeps proving they mostly don't. The kit climbs from a \$600 kettle to a five-figure rig, but for a buy-once brewer in the tropics the priority spend is not the shiniest vessel. It is the box that controls the temperature.

The geography of the hobby is settled. The main subreddit is the welcoming front porch — "is this infected?", "rate my setup", start-extract-or-all-grain — while HomeBrewTalk is the deep, graybeard archive where the water-chemistry and DIY-electrical arguments live, less patient with a lazy question.¹ The retailers MoreBeer and Northern Brewer double as content hubs, and a YouTube roster — David Heath the patient teacher, Short Circuited Brewers the chaos, Clawhammer filming full brew-days on its own kit — carries the technique.¹ The culture's most divisive voice is Brülosophy, founded by a clinical psychologist, which runs "exBEERiments": brew two batches differing by one variable, then blind-triangle-test tasters. Its repeated, provocative finding is that many sacred rules — precise fermentation temperature, even the fashionable pressure fermentation — fail to show up in blind tasting, which the traditionalists on the forums have been arguing about for a decade.²

The gear is a genuine buy-once ladder that starts higher than beginners expect. The \$30 bucket-and-

extract kit is the try-before-you-commit rung this reader skips; the quality entry is an electric all-in-one — a BrewZilla Gen 4.1 at about US\$600 for value, a Grainfather G30 at US\$899 for the premium-mainstream pick, up to the German Speidel Braumeister from roughly €1,850.³ But the lever that actually decides beer quality, and matters most in Singapore, is fermentation control, not the kettle: an Inkbird controller at about US\$30 wired to a second-hand fridge is the single highest-return purchase in the hobby, a stainless conical or a FermZilla pressure fermenter the next step, a glycol chiller (a BrewBuilt IceMaster around US\$700) the tropical endgame.⁴



CONTROL BEATS THE KETTLE

BRÜLOSOPHY VS THE RULES

TEMP IS EVERYTHING HERE

THE CHATTER — "YOU'RE BUYING A FERMENTATION, NOT A KETTLE"

The line the sober guides repeat is the one beginners ignore: the boil looks like brewing, but the ferment makes the beer. On the forums the highest-upvoted advice for a new all-grain brewer is almost never "buy a nicer system" — it is "control your fermentation temperature first," because a cheap kettle with a controlled ferment beats an expensive one without.¹ Brülosophy is the empirical wing of that argument: run the blind test before you spend.²

THE SCEPTIC — THE GEAR THAT DOESN'T TASTE LIKE ITS PRICE

The community's most useful confession: above the quality-entry all-in-one, returns diminish fast. A US\$600 BrewZilla and a US\$4,000 Braumeister make broadly similar beer in a blind glass — the delta is convenience and build, not drinkability — and Brülosophy's blind tests keep deflating the expensive obsessions, from exact ferment temperatures to the fashionable pressure fermentation, which their 2025-26 experiments could not reliably tell from an ambient batch.² The buy-once move is the quality all-in-one plus real temperature control, and the honesty to treat the rest as a hobby, not a cheat that makes better beer.⁴

SOURCES 1 Community map — r/Homebrewing (~1.2M); HomeBrewTalk (deep archive); MoreBeer/Northern Brewer; YouTube (David Heath, Short Circuited Brewers, Clawhammer, The Malt Miller, Basic Brewing) — Feedspot; community, summarised. 2 Brülosophy (Marshall Schott) — "exBEERiments," blind triangle tests; many rules (ferment-temp, pressurised fermentation) not statistically significant; a 2025 Festbier pressure/temperature xBmt and a Jun 2026 pressure meta-analysis both "not significant"; methodology genuinely contested (small panels) — Brülosophy; BYO; HomeBrewTalk. 3 All-in-ones — BrewZilla Gen 4.1 35L ~US\$599.99; Anvil Foundry ~US\$599.95; Grainfather G30 US\$899 / G40 US\$1,499; Zygoborg US\$549; Speidel Braumeister from ~€1,850 (high end) — MoreBeer; Great Fermentations; KegLand; retailer listings, 2026 (spot-check live prices). 4 Fermentation control — Inkbird ITC-308 ~US\$30 + a used fridge; Ss Brew Bucket US\$199; Spike CF conical from ~US\$850; KegLand FermZilla pressure kits; glycol — BrewBuilt IceMaster ~US\$700, Ss Brewtech ~US\$1,099 — Homebrew Finds; BYO; retailer listings, 2026. Prices as found; verify before purchase.

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE DEEP END

Kegs, the Cutting Edge, and the 30°C Problem

Past the kettle lies kegging, then automation, then the year's real flavour wave — engineered "thiol" yeasts that turn beer into a juice bomb. But the deepest question for a Singapore brewer is not gear at all. It is legal, and it is the ambient temperature: at thirty degrees, your yeast will ruin your beer unless you solve for the heat first.

Two upgrades define the deep end. Kegging saves the hobby for people who hate bottling — used Cornelius kegs at US\$40–65, a CO2 cylinder, and the fifty-bottle washing ritual is gone.¹ Beyond it is the custom tier: Raspberry-Pi controllers like CraftBeerPi and BrewPi driving multi-vessel HERMS and RIMS rigs, wired stainless brewhouses past US\$10,000 on the classifieds, and the ghost of PicoBrew, the "magic box" that promised push-button beer and folded in 2020.¹ The genuine cutting edge is at the yeast — engineered "thiolised" strains and Phantasm powder, from Sauvignon Blanc grape skins, biotransforming precursors into passionfruit-and-guava aromatics: a real, dramatic effect when it works, though inconsistent, and mid-2025 saw one maker pull its homebrew-size thiol packs.²

For a Singapore brewer, two facts outrank all the gear. First the law, which is generous: home brewing beer for personal use is exempt from licensing under

the Customs Order of 2008, capped at thirty litres per household per month and not for sale — but distilling anything is illegal without a licence.³ Second the heat, which is unforgiving: at an ambient thirty degrees, standard ale yeast throws harsh fusels and esters, which is why fermentation control is the whole game and why the diehards lean on heat-tolerant strains — Norwegian kveik, clean and fast at thirty-five to forty degrees, and saison. Buy the gear at iBrew in Clementi; save the beer by controlling a fermenter, not a nicer kettle.⁴

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS — A BUY-ONCE PATH IN

Lurk first — a fortnight on r/Homebrewing, HomeBrewTalk and a David Heath brew-day; visit iBrew in Clementi.⁴

System and control — a BrewZilla (~US\$600) or Grainfather G30 (US\$899), plus a used fridge and an Inkbird (~US\$30).⁴

First yeast: kveik — a heat-tolerant Voss survives the ambient thirty degrees before the fridge is even dialled in. All-in ~US\$1,000–1,300.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — THE MONEY PIT, IN THE COMMUNITY'S OWN WORDS

The hobby is engineered for incremental spend — bucket, all-in-one, conical, glycol, kegging, automation — and the "\$5,000 over five years and never cheaper than buying craft beer" confession is the community's, not a critic's.⁵ The honest admissions: your first batches will be worse than store-bought while you learn, the per-pint cost never counts your labour, and the trend-chasing tax is real — the thiol packs vanished. You brew because you like brewing; the classic mistake this reader can avoid is buying too cheap, re-buying, and skimping on the one thing that decides the beer.⁵

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK THE NEXT RABBIT HOLE (TAP A CHIP IN THE READER)

Home espresso — the upgrade treadmill in one square metre, from a Bambino to a Linea Micra, and where the dialling-in finally stops.

Mechanical keyboards — group buys, custom switches and artisan keycaps; a maker-deep world tuned for a sound only the owner hears.

Coral reef aquariums — a living-systems money pit of water chemistry, lighting and livestock, with a serious Singapore scene.

SOURCES ¹ Kegging — used Cornelius kegs US\$40–65 (new US\$90–130), CO2 cylinder; custom/automation — CraftBeerPi & BrewPi (Raspberry-Pi controllers), HERMS/RIMS stainless rigs (\$10k+ on classifieds), PicoBrew folded 2020 — HomeBrewingStore; AHA; GitHub; community; 2026. ² Cutting edge — thiolised yeast + Phantasm powder (Sauvignon Blanc grape-skin, thiol precursors, biotransformed to passionfruit/guava); Omega discontinued homebrew-size 400-series thiol packs Jun 2025, Escarpment Thiol Libre remains; effect real but inconsistent — Escarpment Labs; Northern Brewer; The Mad Fermentationist; BeerSmith, 2025–26. ³ Singapore legality — Customs (Home-Brewing of Fermented Liquors) (Exemption) Order 2008: personal home-brewing exempt from licensing, cap 30 litres/household/month, not for sale; distillation illegal without a licence — Singapore Customs; Singapore Statutes Online. ⁴ Tropical fermentation — ~28–32°C ambient throws fusels/esters with standard ale yeast; kveik (LaBrew Voss, ~35–40°C) and saison as heat-tolerant strains; local supplier iBrew (Clementi) — White Labs; VinePair; iBrew SG; community, 2026. ⁵ Economics/money-pit — "not cheaper than craft beer," equipment creep, "first batches worse than store-bought" — community consensus (HomeBrewTalk; r/Homebrewing), summarised. Next Descents logged in the issue log. Prices as found.

FITNESS · THE LONG GAME

The Shortcut Has a Muscle Bill

New data on the weight-loss drugs adds an awkward finding to a known problem: people losing weight on GLP-1s move less, not more — exactly the wrong behaviour when up to 45% of the weight coming off is muscle. The earned version of the same goal is unglamorous and well-evidenced: a barbell twice a week and a protein target. Not medical advice.

The weight-loss drugs work, and their cost is becoming clearer. Research presented at the Endocrine Society's 2026 meeting found that adults losing weight on GLP-1 receptor agonists significantly *decreased* their physical activity — the precise opposite of what protects muscle during rapid weight loss.¹ That matters because of how the weight comes off: in the semaglutide trials roughly 45% of the loss was lean tissue, and in the tirzepatide data about 25% — a large share of it muscle, the tissue a mid-forties reader spends a decade trying to keep.² The shortcut, in other words, is billed in the currency longevity cares about most. The drug removes the appetite that drove the overeating; it does nothing to remove the need to earn and defend muscle, and the falling activity levels suggest many users are doing less of exactly that.¹

The earned version of the same outcome is dull and well-supported, which is the point of this desk.³ Resistance training two to three times a week, paired

with protein at roughly 1.2 to 1.6 grams per kilogram of body weight a day, cuts the lean-tissue loss toward zero — whether or not a drug is involved.² It threads straight back to last week's finding that cardiorespiratory fitness forecasts brain health a decade out: aerobic capacity and muscle mass are the two physical predictors most tied to a long, capable life, and neither comes in an injection.³ For a reader weighing the drugs — or simply losing weight the ordinary way — the instruction is the same one the whole issue keeps arriving at: take the long way. Lift, eat the protein, and let the scale move slowly enough that muscle survives the trip.³

~45%

OF THE WEIGHT LOST ON SEMAGLUTIDE CAME FROM LEAN TISSUE IN THE TRIAL DATA — MUCH OF IT MUSCLE. RESISTANCE TRAINING PLUS ADEQUATE PROTEIN CUTS THAT TOWARD ZERO; THE DRUG ALONE DOES NOT.²

THE DRUG HAS A MUSCLE BILL

LIFT + PROTEIN

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE CHATTER — THE DEBATE THE LONGEVITY CROWD IS HAVING

The GLP-1-and-muscle question has become the live argument in the longevity discourse the reader follows. At the 2026 diabetes meetings it played out as a genuine debate — Samuel Klein arguing most of the weight lost is fat, with "no evidence" of frailty or sarcopenia in otherwise-healthy people; Eric Ravussin countering that the muscle loss is a real concern for older and higher-risk groups — while Peter Attia has publicly weighed the drugs against aging and cognition.⁴ The consensus the sober voices reach is not "avoid the drugs"; it is "if you use them, lift and eat protein, because the intervention that protects the muscle matters more than which molecule drives the loss."⁴

THE SCEPTIC — DON'T OVERSELL THE PANIC EITHER

Keep the contrarian note honest in both directions. Klein's camp has a real case: GLP-1 weight loss is largely fat, the absolute lean decline is modest, and there is no consistent deterioration in strength or function in healthy adults — so "the drugs melt your muscle" is as overstated as "they're free of cost."⁵ The measured read is that lean loss accompanies *any* rapid weight loss, drug or not, and the fix is the same regardless: resistance training and protein. The drugs are a legitimate tool, especially for high-risk patients; the error is treating them as a substitute for the barbell rather than a reason to pick it up. This is general guidance, not medical advice, and the muscle you keep is built, not injected.³

SOURCES 1 ENDO 2026 (Endocrine Society) — adults losing weight on GLP-1 receptor agonists significantly decreased physical activity — Endocrine Society press release, 2026 (release date HELD; tied to the ENDO 2026 meeting). 2 Lean-mass loss — STEP 1 (semaglutide) body-composition substudy ~45% of weight lost from lean tissue; SURMOUNT-1 (tirzepatide) ~25%; resistance training 2–3x/wk + protein ~1.2–1.6 g/kg/day cuts lean loss toward near-zero — clinical-trial syntheses, 2026. 3 Continuity with No. 66's VO2-max/brain-health finding; aerobic capacity + muscle mass as leading longevity predictors — desk analysis. 4 ADA 2026 debate — Samuel Klein (mostly fat, "no evidence" of frailty/sarcopenia in healthy adults) vs Eric Ravussin (real concern for older/high-risk); Peter Attia on GLP-1s, aging and cognition — Medscape; Attia (public posts), 2026. 5 The muscle-loss "myth vs evidence" case — largely fat, modest absolute lean decline, strength/function preserved in healthy adults — Docwire; Medscape, 2026. General guidance, not medical advice; forecasts and unverifiable figures flagged.

THE TRAVEL DESK • DEPARTURES

The Tax at the Till, and the Suite You Can't Board From Here

Two Japan clocks matter to a Singapore flyer: the departure tax has already tripled, and from November the country ends walk-out tax-free shopping — the friction a camera-buyer will actually feel. Meanwhile the world's largest business seat enters service this month, on the one hub a Changi traveller can't reach it from.

Suitably for this book, the fortnight's travel news lived entirely in the small print. Japan's departure tax has already tripled — from ¥1,000 to ¥3,000, live since 1 July, baked into every air and ferry ticket — and the bigger change lands on 1 November, when the country switches tax-free shopping from an instant in-store exemption to a refund-at-departure system: pay the full 10% consumption tax at the till, reclaim it at the airport before you fly.¹ For anyone picking up a Leica body or a set of headphones on a Tokyo trip, that is the change that stings — the tax comes off at a counter before departure now, not at the till in Bic Camera.¹ Europe's clock moved the other way: the biometric Entry/Exit System is now fully operational and taking fingerprints at Schengen borders, while ETIAS, the €20 pre-travel authorisation, has slipped to 2027.²

On the aircraft, the headline is a seat you cannot book from here. ANA's "THE Room FX," billed as the world's largest business-class suite — sliding doors, a

sofa-style bed, a 24-inch screen — enters service this month on the 787-9, but deploys Haneda-to-long-haul on US and European routes, with no confirmed ex-Singapore rotation.³ Closer to home the wins are quieter: Changi was again named the world's best airport in the 2026 Skytrax results, its Jewel lounge shower rooms are shut for a refurbishment through late November, and the post-Jetstar-Asia network has largely settled — Scoot backfilling Okinawa and frequency bumps, SIA's First Class restored on the Amsterdam route from July.⁴ Read the milestones carefully; the ones that matter to a plan are the entry rules, not the renders.¹

1 Nov

THE DAY JAPAN ENDS WALK-OUT TAX-FREE SHOPPING FOR A REFUND-AT-DEPARTURE SYSTEM — THE FRICTION A BIG-PURCHASE TRAVELLER FEELS FAR MORE THAN THE ¥3,000 DEPARTURE TAX THAT ALREADY TRIPLED IN JULY.¹

JAPAN TAX-FREE ENDS 1 NOV

CHANGI #1 AGAIN

ANA SUITE, NOT EX-SIN

THE CHATTER — THE REFUND-QUEUE GRUMBLE

The change already lighting up the frequent-flyer forums is the Japan tax-free switch, and the complaint is specific: readers who plan a big camera or audio purchase on a Tokyo trip will now front the 10% consumption tax and queue for a refund at the airport, cashflow and time both.⁵ The counsel that circulates is practical — either front-load a big buy onto a pre-November trip to keep the walk-out window, or budget the airport refund line after. It is the same lesson this desk keeps relearning: a posted rule and a lived queue are two different things until you are standing in one, receipts in hand.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — MIND WHICH DATES ARE REAL

Some of the week's milestones are softer than they read. The JB-Singapore RTS Link's "completion by end-2026" is a construction-completion target, not a boarding date — passenger service is guided to early 2027, and printing "trains by Christmas" would be exactly the ledger-versus-memory error the book warns against.⁶ ANA's world-largest suite is real and entering service, but not on any routing a Changi flyer can currently reach, so it changes no plan out of Singapore this year.³ And the Skytrax "ninth time" for Changi should be checked against the primary result before it is quoted as gospel.⁴ Book on the confirmed cabins and the live entry rules; treat every "coming soon" as a target until a ticket is on sale.

SOURCES 1 Japan — departure tax tripled ¥1,000 → ¥3,000, live from 1 Jul 2026 (all nationalities, in every ticket); tax-free shopping switches to refund-at-departure from 1 Nov 2026 — Japan Times; MATCHA; Travel Voice, 2026. 2 EU — Entry/Exit System (EES) fully operational (phased from Oct 2025; complete ~Apr 2026), biometrics at Schengen borders; ETIAS (€20) now expected 2027 — EC Home Affairs; etias.com, 2026. 3 ANA "THE Room FX" (787-9; claimed world's-largest business seat — sliding doors, sofa-bed, 24" screen) enters service Aug 2026, Haneda long-haul (LA/NY/London/Frankfurt cited); no confirmed ex-SIN routing (HELD) — ANA Holdings; AwardFares, 2026. 4 Changi named World's Best Airport 2026 (Skytrax; "9th time" — verify vs primary, HELD); Jewel "Changi Lounge" shower rooms shut ~1 Aug-end-Nov 2026; post-Jetstar-Asia network settled (Scoot Okinawa 4x/wk + frequency bumps); SIA First restored SIN-Amsterdam from 1 Jul (continuity) — Jewel Changi; TTG Asia; Travel And Tour World, 2026. 5 Community read — FlyerTalk/The Milelion threads (the Japan tax-free grumble), summarised, not fetched live. 6 JB-Singapore RTS Link — end-2026 completion target (construction); passenger service guided early 2027 — Malay Mail; Yahoo SG, 2026 (HELD on service date). New-Peg Test applied; already-tracked reforms run as deltas.

THE TRAVEL DESK · THE ROUNDUP

In Brief — Livery, Lounges and the Ski Pipeline

The smaller items worth a Changi flyer's attention: a loyalty deadline to note, a Niseko hotel pipeline for two winters out, a lounge or two back to full hours, and a superhero livery your daughter will spot on the apron.

KrisFlyer's quiet clock **POINTS** — after the late-2025 devaluation and a March "Access" tweak, pre-devaluation award rates survive only for travel on or before 21 October 2026; dynamic pricing is now live. Sitting on miles for a year-end premium seat? The cheaper chart is a deadline, not a rate.¹

Niseko's pipeline **HOTEL** — Hotel101-Niseko (482 rooms) opens December 2026 and Fairmont Niseko is inked for early 2028. For a keep-it reader, Hotel101 is a volume-value brand; the Park Hyatt Hanazono / Ritz-Carlton Reserve bench still holds, with Fairmont the 2028 story.²

Scoot's superhero **LIVERY** — a Spider-Man "Brand New Day" livery flies on a Scoot A321neo and 787 until

13 September — a small, free bit of delight for the family flyer, and a spotting game for an eleven-year-old at the gate.³

Melbourne & the hubs **LOUNGE** — SIA's rebuilt SilverKris lounge in Melbourne opened in June, and the Qantas Singapore Business lounge is back to morning openings — small quality-of-life deltas on the usual routings.⁴

Cairns, one more weekly **NEW ROUTE** — the SIN-Cairns nonstop went four-to-five weekly on the A350 for the 7 Jul-22 Sep peak, a marginal but useful bump for the reef gateway this desk covered at No. 59.⁴

The gear cross-reference

TRAVEL TECH — the travel-camera question this fortnight is The Kit's

(p9): Insta360's X6 opens pre-orders 12 August. We won't duplicate it, but a one-inch 360 that reframes later is a genuine carry-on candidate for the trip overleaf.⁵

Japan's autumn window **TIMING** — the Nagano foliage the Grand Tour covers (p21) peaks mid-October to early November; JR-pass holders should reserve the limited-express Azusa seats and the Kiso post-town lodging weeks ahead, as both are thin at peak.⁶

Changi's lounge caveat **LOUNGE** — Jewel's Changi Lounge shower rooms are shut for refurbishment through late November; transit travellers counting on a pre-flight shower there should route to a terminal lounge instead this quarter.⁴

A posted rule and a lived queue are two different things until you are standing in one, receipts in hand.

PLANNING NOTES — THE FORTNIGHT'S ACTIONABLE DATES

Japan buyers: if a big camera or audio purchase is on the itinerary, weigh a pre-1-November trip to keep the walk-out tax-free window, or budget the airport refund queue after.⁶ **KrisFlyer holders:** 21 October is the cliff for the old award chart on year-end travel — price the seat now.¹ **Europe-bound:** fingerprints at the EES border now, but no ETIAS form to fill yet — that is a 2027 job.⁶ **Nagano-bound (overleaf):** book the Kiso Valley lodging early for the autumn foliage window; the post-town rooms are few.⁶

THE SCEPTIC — THE INFRASTRUCTURE THAT ISN'T RUNNING YET

Two big-ticket projects will be sold to you as imminent and are not. The RTS Link's end-2026 target is construction, not boarding, with passenger service guided to 2027; and ANA's world-largest suite, real as it is, reaches no Singapore routing this year.⁷ Treat every "coming soon" in a travel headline as a target, not a timetable. The Grand Tour overleaf is planned around what actually runs today — the limited express to Matsumoto, the local train down the Kiso valley, and the post road you cross on your own two feet.⁷

SOURCES 1 KrisFlyer — Nov-2025 devaluation + Mar-2026 "Access" tweak; pre-devaluation award rates for travel on/before 21 Oct 2026; dynamic Access pricing live — Mainly Miles; SingSaver, 2025-26. 2 Hotel101-Niseko (482 rooms) opens Dec 2026; Fairmont Niseko signed for early 2028 — Travel And Tour World; Accor, 2026. 3 Scoot Spider-Man "Brand New Day" livery (A321neo + 787) through 13 Sep 2026 — flyscoot media centre, 2026. 4 SIA rebuilt Melbourne SilverKris lounge opened Jun 2026; Qantas Singapore Business lounge morning openings; SIN-Cairns 4-5 weekly (A350) for 7 Jul-22 Sep — Aviation A2Z; Mainly Miles, 2026. 5 Cross-reference The Kit (p9); Insta360 X6 pre-orders 12 Aug. 6 EU EES live, ETIAS 2027; Japan tax-free window (see p19) — etias.com; Travel Voice, 2026. 7 RTS Link end-2026 completion (construction) / early-2027 service; ANA "THE Room FX" no ex-SIN routing — Malay Mail; ANA Holdings, 2026 (HELD). Discrete Departures items logged to the Coverage Ledger under the New-Peg Test.

THE GRAND TOUR • MATSUMOTO & THE KISO VALLEY

The Black Castle and the Road You Walk

Two and a half hours west of the Shinkansen crowds, Nagano keeps a Japan the bullet train skips: an original black castle, the Japan Alps on the horizon, and a preserved Edo highway you still cross on foot between post towns. This is the long way round, and it is the point of the trip.

Nagano is the antidote to the Golden Route. Matsumoto, its castle city, sits about two and a half to three hours from Shinjuku on the limited express Azusa — roughly ¥6,730, covered by the JR passes — and from there the Kiso Valley opens south, reached by local trains on the Chuo line to Nakatsugawa or Nagiso.¹ The soft yen makes it cheaper than it has been in years: cross-reference the currency read on the Macro Desk, where a firm Singapore dollar stretches a Nagano trip further than a Tokyo one.² When to go is the whole game. The window to chase is mid-October into early November, when the Nakasendo maples peak and the Alps clear; late April and May bring castle blossoms and thinner crowds.³ Avoid the rainy season from mid-June, and the hot, humid, insect-heavy valleys of high summer; winter leaves the post towns walkable but cold, and closes the alpine valley of Kamikochi entirely from mid-November.³

Where to base is the decision that shapes the trip. Matsumoto city is the comfortable hub — real hotels, the castle, the Kusama art museum, and easy day

trips to the wasabi farm, Narai and the alps — and the natural choice for travelling with a child.⁴ But the payoff the day-trippers miss is a night in a Kiso post town. Stay in a family-run minshuku in Tsumago and the place empties after five o'clock, the tour buses gone, the lantern-lit street falling to a stillness the guidebooks call almost enchanting, with a multi-dish home-cooked dinner to match — the trade being tatami, a shared bath, cash only and little English.⁴ The forum consensus is to do both: a comfortable Matsumoto base, and one deliberate night on the old road, so you see the post town after the crowds have driven home.⁵

~2.5h

FROM SHINJUKU TO MATSUMOTO ON THE LIMITED EXPRESS AZUSA (~¥6,730, JR-PASS ELIGIBLE) — THE SHORT RIDE THAT SKIPS THE GOLDEN ROUTE AND OPENS THE KISO ROAD, THE ALPS AND THE CASTLE CITY.¹

JAPAN BEYOND THE BULLET TRAIN

AUTUMN IS THE WINDOW

BASE MATSUMOTO, SLEEP THE KISO

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

The consensus across r/JapanTravel and the trip-report threads is warmer about the region than about any single sight. Matsumoto Castle is "worth it, but combined" — striking from the outside and reflected in its moat, cramped and steep on the inside, and "not worth a Tokyo side-trip on its own" — earning its place as the anchor of a wider Nagano loop rather than a standalone.⁵ A vocal minority push the post-town overnight hard: the empty-town stillness after five is the whole reason to come, and day-tripping Tsumago-Magome at midday, when the buses arrive, is the common mistake — walk it early or late.⁵ The quiet tip the guides keep repeating is Narai: the longest of the post towns and the least touristed, reachable straight from Matsumoto, the one the crowds skip and the regulars rate.⁵

SOURCES 1 Getting there — ex-SIN to Tokyo (Haneda/Narita) or Nagoya (Chubu Centrair); Matsumoto via JR Ltd Express Azusa from Shinjuku ~2.5–3h (~¥6,730, JR-pass/JR East eligible), or Ltd Express Shinano from Nagoya ~2h; Kiso Valley via the Chuo line (Nakatsugawa for Magome, Nagiso for Tsumago; local trains for Narai ~45–55 min from Matsumoto) — SnowMonkeyResorts; jprail.com, 2026. 2 FX — soft yen vs SGD; cross-ref The Macro Desk (p14); no rate invented (HELD). 3 When to go — mid-Oct–early Nov (Nakasendo foliage, clear Alps); late Apr–May (castle blossoms, thinner crowds); avoid mid-Jun rainy season and hot/humid high summer; Kamikochi season ~17 Apr–15 Nov — SnowMonkeyResorts; go-nagano.net; gaijinpot, 2026. 4 Where to base — Matsumoto city (hotels, castle, Kusama museum, day-trip hub; best with a child) vs a Kiso post-town minshuku (Tsumago's after-5pm stillness, home-cooked meals; tatami/shared bath/cash-only) — travelwithapen; trip.com "moments," 2026. 5 "What the forums say" — r/JapanTravel; TripAdvisor Matsumoto/Kiso; guide blogs — castle striking-outside/cramped-inside and "worth it combined"; stay a post-town night; Narai underrated; walk Tsumago-Magome early/late — paraphrased, no quotes invented (primary threads not fetched live).

THE GRAND TOUR • MATSUMOTO & THE KISO VALLEY

The Walk, the Wasabi, and the Craft Worth Carrying Home

Walk Magome to Tsumago downhill, forward your bag ahead, and ring the bear bells. Buy the lacquerware where it is made. See the castle for the moat, not the climb. The honest version of Nagano's greatest hits — including the ice cream everyone photographs and half the reviewers regret.

The signature walk is the eight kilometres between Magome and Tsumago, and the trick is direction: go Magome to Tsumago and you climb to the pass then run mostly downhill, three to four hours through cedar forest and stone-paved Edo sections, past the Odaki and Medaki waterfalls and a free volunteer-run tea house, ringing the posted bear bells as you go.¹ The baggage-forwarding service between the two tourist offices, about ¥1,000 a bag dropped mid-morning, means you walk it unencumbered — a genuinely doable adventure for a fit eleven-year-old, not a slog.¹ Matsumoto Castle, the original late-sixteenth-century black keep and a National Treasure, is the region's icon; take it for the moat reflection, and know the interior climb is steep and cramped, a caveat the reviews are honest about.² Narai, the longest and quietest post town, sits a short local-train ride from the city, and beside it Kiso-Hirasawa is the lacquerware capital — the buy-once craft to carry home, bought where it is actually made.²

The rest is small pleasures done well. The Daio Wasabi Farm near Azumino is Japan's largest, free, its

spring-fed channels photogenic and its wasabi soft-serve the thing everyone orders and some quietly regret — pay for the fresh-wasabi dollop and it improves.³ The Matsumoto City Museum of Art holds the polka-dot world of Yayoi Kusama, born here, and Kamikochi, an hour out by the car-free park bus, gives flat riverside walks under the Hotaka peaks in season.³ Eat the Shinshu soba, the garlic-fried sanzoku-yaki chicken, and the baked oyaki dumplings that are Nagano's own. Money runs cheaper than Tokyo, the soft yen helping: a minshuku with two meals ~¥9,000–15,000 a head, a hotel ¥12,000–25,000, the castle ¥700 — indicative, not invented.⁵

~¥1,000

TO FORWARD YOUR BAG BETWEEN THE MAGOME AND TSUMAGO TOURIST OFFICES — THE SMALL FEE THAT TURNS THE EIGHT-KILOMETRE POST-ROAD WALK FROM A HAUL INTO A HANDS-FREE STROLL A CHILD CAN MANAGE.¹

MAGOME → TSUMAGO, DOWNHILL

BUY THE LACQUER AT SOURCE

SOBA, WASABI, KUSAMA

THE MONEY & THE LIGHT — FOR THE SHOOTER WHO PLANS THIS

For a Leica or a film body this is a texture-and-season trip, not a checklist: the moat mirror at Matsumoto in still morning light, the stone-paved Nakasendo under cedar in low autumn sun, the wooden shopfronts of Narai empty before the day trains.² The soft yen (cross-ref the Macro Desk, p14) makes the craft the affordable indulgence — a piece of Kiso lacquer bought in Kiso-Hirasawa is the buy-once souvenir, and costs less than anywhere the tour buses stop. Bring warm layers and a neutral-density filter for the waterfalls.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — THE HONEST DISAPPOINTMENTS

Be candid about what underwhelms. The castle's interior is a steep, cramped climb that does not match the exterior — go for the moat, manage the stairs.² The famous wasabi soft-serve leaves a fair share shrugging; it is mild, worth it only with the fresh-wasabi add-on.³ And the Magome-Tsumago walk, magical early and late, clogs with day-trippers midday, especially autumn weekends — the fix is the post-town overnight, not an earlier alarm.¹ None of it makes Nagano less than a great trip; it makes it one you do the slow way, which is the reason to come.¹

SOURCES 1. Tsumago-Magome walk (~8km, ~3–4h) — go Magome → Tsumago (climb to Magome-tōge then net downhill); stone-paved Edo sections, cedar forest, Odaki/Medaki waterfalls, a free volunteer tea house; posted bear bells; baggage forwarding between tourist offices ~¥1,000/bag (drop mid-morning); shuttle for the return — gajjinpot; reallyruraljapan.com, 2026. Midday day-tripper crowds, esp. autumn weekends. 2. Matsumoto Castle (Matsumotojo) — original late-16th-c black keep, National Treasure, Japan's oldest five-tier donjon; moat reflection the shot, steep/cramped interior (~¥700); Narai the longest/quietest post town; Kiso-Hirasawa the Kiso-lacquer (shikki) town — thiswaytojapan; japan.travel; visitmatsumoto, 2026. 3. Daio Wasabi Farm (Azumino; free; spring channels; wasabi soft-serve mild, better with fresh-wasabi add-on); Matsumoto City Museum of Art (Yayoi Kusama, Matsumoto-born); Kamikochi (car-free, National Park bus from Matsumoto; season ~17 Apr–15 Nov) — japan-guide; matsumoto-artmuse.jp; kamikochi.org, 2026. 4. Food — Shinshu soba, sanzoku-yaki, oyaki, Kiso gohei-mochi; craft cross-ref (buy lacquer at source) — regional guides, summarised. 5. Money (indicative) — minshuku w/ 2 meals ~¥9,000–15,000 pp; Matsumoto hotel ~¥12,000–25,000; castle ¥700; bag forward ¥1,000; Azusa ~¥6,730 — listings; totals indicative, HELD. Soft yen helps; cross-ref p14. Forum sentiment flagged; no fare/quote invented.

THE DIARY · THE AGENDA

What's Worth Booking

Seats for the Tokyo autumn sumo tournament went on sale this weekend, and the good ones empty within hours. Beyond it, a packed Singapore quarter fronted by the Grand Prix's first-ever Sprint weekend.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 9–11 Oct

★ **F1 Singapore Grand Prix**

MARINA BAY · THE FIRST-EVER SG SPRINT WEEKEND; PADANG ACTS INCLUDE GOO GOO DOLLS, SPLIT ENZ, MARK RONSON, DJ SNAKE — HEADLINERS STILL LANDING. BUY THE WEEKEND PASS, NOT A SINGLE DAY
- 2–3 Oct

★ **The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn**

NATIONAL STADIUM · TWO NIGHTS, WITH JAPAN'S CREEPY NUTS SUPPORTING; ON SALE (TICKETMASTER SG)
- 25 SEP

Post Malone

NATIONAL STADIUM · BIG ASS WORLD TOUR
- 19 SEP

Kit Chan — Atrium Live Tour

INDOOR STADIUM · HOMEGROWN DIVA; BROAD APPEAL
- 4 NOV

LANY — Soft 2

INDOOR STADIUM · ON SALE (TICKETMASTER)
- 17–22 Dec

BTS — sold out

NATIONAL STADIUM · FOUR NIGHTS, RESALE ONLY; WATCH FOR SCAM LISTINGS

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 13–27 Sep

★ **Aki Basho — Grand Sumo**

RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · TICKETS RELEASED THIS WEEKEND; ARENA FROM ~¥3,500, BOX ~¥8K–15K/PAX — SET UP TICKET ŌSUMO NOW, WEEKEND SEATS GO WITHIN HOURS
- late Sep

Tokyo Game Show

MAKUHARI MESSE · TECH-FORWARD, AND A HIT WITH AN ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD
- 18–20 Sep

Kishiwada Danjiri Matsuri

OSAKA · THE SPECTACULAR CART-PULLING FESTIVAL; A KANSAI DAY-TRIP, FREE FROM THE STREET
- 22 OCT

Jidai Matsuri

KYOTO · THE FESTIVAL OF THE AGES, A COSTUMED PROCESSION THROUGH THE OLD CAPITAL
- 22 Oct–3 Nov

Tokyo Ramen Festival

KOMAZAWA OLYMPIC PARK · DOZENS OF SHOPS, LIMITED BOWLS; KID-FRIENDLY

PLANNING NOTES

TIMING · SELL-OUTS · FAMILY

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Sumo went on sale this weekend: set up a Ticket Ōsumo account now — the boxes and weekend days go within hours.¹ **F1:** 2026 adds Singapore's first Sprint, so Saturday is a full race day — buy the weekend pass. **Hotels:** race weekend (9–11 Oct) and the Weeknd nights (2–3 Oct) will be brutal; lock rooms now. **BTS'** four December nights stay sold out — verified resale only, mind the scams.¹

FURTHER AFIELD — WORTH THE FLIGHT

- Jidai Matsuri + koyo** — pair Kyoto's 22 Oct procession with the first autumn colour for a single well-timed week.¹
- Kishiwada Danjiri** — 18–20 Sep, Osaka; one of Japan's most thrilling festivals, free from the street.¹
- Aki Basho weekend seats** — target 19–20 Sep for a Saturday–Sunday of sumo; the middle days book easiest.¹

SOURCES ¹ F1 Singapore GP 9–11 Oct 2026 (first SG Sprint; Padang acts incl. Goo Goo Dolls, Split Enz, Mark Ronson, DJ Snake; headliners TBA; grandstand S\$198–1,198) — singapore.gp; The Smart Local. The Weeknd 2–3 Oct (w/ Creepy Nuts), Post Malone 25 Sep, Kit Chan 19 Sep, LANY 4 Nov — Harper's Bazaar SG; Ticketmaster SG. BTS four National Stadium nights (17/19/20/22 Dec) sold out, resale only (continuity; scam caution) — Live Nation SG. Aki Basho tickets released ~8 Aug (tournament 13–27 Sep, Ryōgoku Kokugikan; arena from ~¥3,500, box ~¥8,000–15,000 pp) — Tokyo Cheapo; ryogokukokugikan.com. Tokyo Game Show (Sep, Makuhari Messe); Kishiwada Danjiri 18–20 Sep; Jidai Matsuri 22 Oct; Tokyo Ramen Festival 22 Oct–3 Nov — MATCHA; Kanpai-Japan. Dates verified against official/primary where possible; on-sale windows as advised.

THE TABLE • NEWLY OPEN

Singapore's Newest Tables

A Tokyo Michelin chef brings a ten-seat omakase to the Capitol; the pedigreed Neil Road Italian from last week has opened, drawing praise for — of all things — a mountain of butter; and the Jeju-pork cutlet house has earned its verdict.

The headline arrival is Sushi Ryujiro, the Singapore debut of the Tokyo chef Ryujiro Nakamura, whose counter has held a Michelin star since 2021 — a snug ten-seat edomae omakase inside the Capitol Kempinski, seafood flown from Japan four times a week and sourced from independent fishermen rather than the wholesale market.¹ It is the classic book-ahead setup: ten seats, real pedigree, and prices to match — a nigiri lunch around S\$228, lunch omakase near S\$298, dinner from about S\$428.¹ With the counter barely open it is, in truth, unripe for a plate-level call; the pedigree earns the booking, a fortnight of covers the judgement.¹ Book it if a special-occasion Japanese counter is the point, and go in curious.¹

The one that has moved from preview to praise is Assaggi, the second restaurant from Denis Lucchi of one-Michelin Buona Terra, which opened on 10 August on Neil Road.² The early reception is warm and specific: reviewers frame it as "Buona Terra at a fraction of the price," set menus only, the showstopper a mountain of whipped Beppino Occelli butter with honey-glazed brioche, cocktails from the speakeasy Bar Kakure singled out.² The basics are gentle for the pedigree — lunch from S\$58, the

Signature and Pasta journeys at S\$88 — the new peg that turns last week's "opening 10 August" into "open, and the first reviews are good."²

And the one now ripe for a verdict is Katsu by Kyu, in OUE Downtown — the city's first cutlet specialist working only in Jeju pork, dry-aged ten days and finished over rice-straw charcoal tableside, first noted at No. 64 and reviewed since.³ Singapore's food writers are favourable on the marbling and the crust, with the usual grumble about premium pricing against a heartland cutlet; now-open has become now-reviewed, and it earns a confident recommendation. One to watch, too new to call: Jing Studio, an eight-seat tea bar in the 140-year-old House of Tan Yeok Nee, teas from S\$7.³

Reserve the pedigreed rooms with curiosity; trust the reviewed ones on their reviews; let the ten-seat counter cook a fortnight before the verdict.

SUSHI RYUJIRO • CAPITOL

ASSAGGI • NEIL ROAD

KATSU BY KYU • OUE

THE BUZZ — THE MEDIA AHEAD OF THE DINERS, AS EVER

The pattern holds: the food media have written up all four, the diners are catching up. Sushi Ryujiro carries the anticipation on Nakamura's star but no consensus yet; Assaggi has warm early reviews (that butter is doing real work); Katsu by Kyu is the settled recommendation.² Book the counters if you enjoy being early; take the reviewed two on their reviews.³

THE SCEPTIC — A LAUNCH MENU IS NOT A SETTLED KITCHEN

Hold the openings to the desk's standard. A ten-seat omakase on opening week, however starred the chef, has not proven consistency across a run of covers — a counter on night one is an intention, not a record, and Sushi Ryujiro earns its verdict in a month, not this week.¹ The honest hierarchy: two reviewed rooms you can book with confidence (Assaggi, Katsu by Kyu) and two still finding their feet (Sushi Ryujiro, Jing Studio). Chase the new counters if you enjoy the risk; save the expectation for the kitchens that have cooked a few hundred covers. None is halal; check before you book.¹

SOURCES 1 Sushi Ryujiro — Singapore debut of Tokyo chef Ryujiro Nakamura (one Michelin star since 2021); 10-seat edomae omakase at the Capitol Kempinski; seafood flown from Japan 4x/week from independent fishermen; nigiri lunch ~S\$228 / lunch omakase ~S\$298 / dinner ~S\$428 — Time Out Singapore; SG City Guide, Aug 2026. Too new to call. Not halal. 2 Assaggi, 77A Neil Road — 2nd restaurant from Denis Lucchi (one-Michelin Buona Terra); opened 10 Aug 2026; set menus only, lunch S\$58++, Signature/Pasta Journeys S\$88++; early reviews warm ("Buona Terra at a fraction of the price"; whipped Beppino Occelli butter + honey-glazed brioche; Bar Kakure cocktails) — middleclass.sg; FACT; Time Out SG, Aug 2026. New peg: opening → open-and-reviewed. Not halal. 3 Katsu by Kyu, OUE Downtown — Singapore's first all-Jeju-pork tonkatsu specialist (10-day dry-aged, rice-straw charcoal, gamasot rice); first reviews favourable (marbling/crust; premium-pricing caveat) — Eatbook; Daniel Food Diary, 4 Aug 2026. New peg: now-open → now-reviewed (first listed No. 64). Jing Studio (8-seat tea bar, House of Tan Yeok Nee, teas from S\$7) — too new — Eatbook, Aug 2026. Not halal. Buzz summarised in our own words; SG food-media/socials not fetched live this session.

THE LONG READ • THE UNDERCURRENT

Vietnam Builds an Idol Factory

Two years ago Vietnam imported its pop spectacle — Blackpink filled a Hanoi stadium and left. Now it manufactures its own: home-grown survival shows minting domestic idols, stadium tours selling out in forty-five minutes, and a government writing "the concert economy" into its plan for GDP. It is South Korea's Hallyu playbook, run in fast-forward — and the West has not noticed.

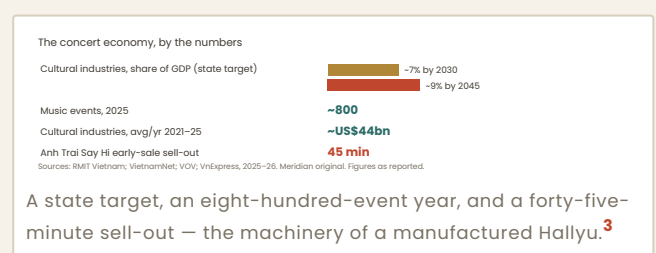
In the summer of 2024 two television shows changed what Vietnam exports. *Anh Trai Vượt Ngàn Chông Gai* — "Brothers Who Overcome All Odds" — and *Anh Trai Say Hi* aired at once, reality-survival formats that took established male performers and, over a season of eliminations, forged them into idols with fandoms.¹ The shows spun off stadium concerts drawing tens of thousands, and a phrase entered the language: *kinh tế concert*, the concert economy.² The scale arrived fast. Vietnam staged roughly eight hundred music-related events in 2025, billed as the most concert-heavy year in its history, and the demand signals are the ones a Korea-watcher recognises instantly — an *Anh Trai Say Hi* early-sale selling out in forty-five minutes, websites crashing under the load, resale prices running three to eight times face.³ A country that a year earlier queued for foreign stars was suddenly queuing for its own.³

What makes this an essay rather than a listings item is the actor behind it: the state. Vietnam's government has formally folded the creative industries into its growth strategy, targeting cultural output at around 7% of GDP by 2030 and 9% by 2045 — and the numbers are already large, the cultural industries averaging on the order of forty-four billion US dollars a year across 2021–2025, their establishment count growing about seven per cent annually.⁴ The listed company behind *Anh Trai Vượt Ngàn Chông Gai*, Yeah1, saw quarterly revenue roughly triple.⁴ This is not a country having a good concert summer. It is a middle-income Southeast Asian state deciding, deliberately and on the record, that manufacturing idols is macroeconomic policy — and betting it can convert reality-television virality

into a durable export sector before the novelty runs out.⁴

The mechanism is worth naming, because it is the tell. A survival-format television season is a machine for compressing the years a normal music industry needs to build a star into a single televised summer — the auditions, the narrative arc, the fan attachment, the graduation into a touring act, all delivered in one broadcast quarter. Vietnam did not invent that machine; it licensed it, from the Chinese and Korean formats that perfected it, and pointed it at its own performers. The result is a star pipeline with the throughput of a factory line and the emotional pull of a serialised drama — which is exactly why the demand arrived faster than anyone's infrastructure was ready for.²

A year earlier, Vietnam queued for foreign stars. Now it queues for its own — and the government is counting the receipts toward a GDP target.



45 min

TO SELL OUT AN *ANH TRAI SAY HI* EARLY SALE — WEBSITES CRASHING, RESALE AT THREE-TO-EIGHT TIMES FACE. THE DEMAND A KOREA-WATCHER RECOGNISES ON SIGHT.³

SOURCES 1 *Anh Trai Vượt Ngàn Chông Gai* ("Brothers Who Overcome All Odds") and *Anh Trai Say Hi* — Vietnamese reality-survival music shows airing summer 2024, minting domestic male idols and spinning off stadium concerts (ATVNCG reported as a licensed adaptation of China's *Call Me by Fire* — HELD) — VietnamNet; VnExpress International, 2024–26. 2 "Kinh tế concert" (concert economy) as a self-conscious phrase in Hanoi/HCMC — VietnamNet; VIR, 2025–26. 3 ~800 music-related events in Vietnam in 2025 (RMIT Vietnam *Music Landscape 2025–26*); *Anh Trai Say Hi* early sale sold out in 45 min, sites crashed, resale 3–8x face (face ~VND 500k–2.6m) — RMIT Vietnam; Vietcetera; VnExpress, 2025–26. 4 State target — cultural industries ~7% of GDP by 2030, ~9% by 2045 (Strategy for Development of Cultural Industries); cultural industries ~VND 1.059 quadrillion (~US\$44bn) avg annual 2021–25, establishments +~7.21%/yr; Yeah1 Group (HOSE-listed, organiser of ATVNCG) quarterly revenue ~tripled — VietnamNet; VOV; company filings (verify), 2025–26. Numbers cross-corroborated across ≥2 sources but gathered via search summaries (primary Vietnamese outlets egress-blocked); figures flagged for a desk-check before treating as precise.

To see what Vietnam is attempting, look at the country it is copying. After the 1997 Asian Financial Crisis, South Korea made a deliberate choice to treat cultural content as a national export industry — funding it, deregulating it, building the label ecosystems and the training pipelines that two decades later produced BTS, *Squid Game* and a K-beauty aisle in every airport, until culture became a genuine balance-of-payments asset.¹ Hallyu was not an accident; it was industrial policy that worked. Vietnam in 2026 is standing at roughly Korea's 2001 moment, with the same ambition and the same state backing — but attempting the leap by a different route. Where Korea built the infrastructure first and the stars followed, Vietnam is manufacturing the stars first, through licensed reality formats borrowed from China and Korea, and hoping the infrastructure assembles itself around the demand.¹

That difference is the whole wager, and the cultural commentators inside Vietnam see it clearly. The argument they make, in the state and trade press, is that a viral season is not yet an industry: for Vietnamese music to become real soft power the way Korea's did, it needs, in the words of one cultural expert, an ecosystem "systematically invested in every aspect" — labels, management, songwriting, touring infrastructure — rather than a hit show every summer.² The tell that they are right to worry is already visible. The second season of *Anh Trai Say Hi*, despite heavier production spend, was widely reported to have "left a large void" against the first — the classic novelty-decay of a reality format — even as the scalping and the crashing ticket sites signalled demand outrunning the systems built to serve it.³

Korea built the infrastructure first and the stars followed. Vietnam is building the stars first, and betting the infrastructure assembles around them.

There is a deeper reason this matters to a Singapore reader, and it is not nostalgia for a good concert.

SOURCES 1 South Korea's post-1997 choice to treat cultural content as a national export industry (funding, deregulation, label/training infrastructure) → Hallyu (BTS, *Squid Game*, K-beauty) as a balance-of-payments asset — widely documented cultural-economic history; the Korea/Vietnam parallel is the desk's argument. 2 Vietnamese cultural commentators — a viral season is not yet an industry; soft power needs an ecosystem "systematically invested in every aspect" (cultural expert Tran Thang Long, as reported) — VietnamNet, 2025–26 (verbatim wording to confirm — HELD). 3 *Anh Trai Say Hi* Season 2 reported to have "left a large void" vs Season 1 despite heavier spend (novelty decay); scalping and crashing ticket sites as demand-outruns-systems signals — Lao Dong; VnExpress; vietnam.vn, 2025–26 (as reported). 4 Cultural exports as durable, high-margin soft power; the regional read-through for Singapore's venues/tours — desk analysis on the reported figures (see p25). Numbers via search summaries (primary Vietnamese outlets egress-blocked); flagged for desk-check.

Cultural exports are among the highest-margin, most durable forms of soft power a middle-income country can build — they travel without tariffs, they age into tourism and brand equity, and they are extraordinarily hard to reverse once established. If Vietnam succeeds, the next regional culture power is a two-hour flight north, assembling in public, and it will reshape the flow of tours, fandoms and spending across Southeast Asia in ways that reach Singapore's own venues and calendars.⁴ If it fails — if the seasons stop converting to a system — it will be a cautionary tale about mistaking a viral summer for an industry. Either way, the experiment is live, it is state-sponsored, and it is being run at a speed no previous cultural power attempted.⁴

It is worth being precise about what is genuinely novel here, because "another country wants a K-pop industry" undersells it. Plenty of governments have wished for Hallyu; what Vietnam has done is stand up the demand side first, at scale, using formats it did not have to invent — and then let the state treat the resulting ticket sales as a policy metric rather than a cultural happy accident. That inversion is the experiment. Korea proved culture could be engineered over a generation; Vietnam is testing whether the same result can be compressed into an election cycle by manufacturing the audience before the industry exists to serve it. If it holds, the playbook becomes exportable to every ambitious middle-income economy with a young population and a streaming habit — which is most of Southeast Asia.⁴

Korea proved culture could be engineered over a generation. Vietnam is testing whether it can be compressed into an election cycle.

~US\$44bn

THE AVERAGE ANNUAL VALUE OF VIETNAM'S CULTURAL INDUSTRIES ACROSS 2021–25, THE BASE THE STATE NOW WANTS TO GROW TOWARD 7% OF GDP — THE RECEIPTS A CONCERT ECONOMY IS BEING ASKED TO SWELL.⁴

The counter-argument earns a fair hearing, because it is a good one. A concert economy built on survival-show seasons is, by construction, exposed to the thing every reality format eventually meets: the audience's attention moving on. Season two already wobbled; the scalping and the site-crashes read as easily as symptoms of a fad peaking as of an industry maturing.¹ Vietnam is attempting Korea's outcome without Korea's twenty-year foundation of labels, songwriting rooms and management systems — the unglamorous plumbing that let Hallyu survive any single group's decline. And the state's involvement cuts both ways: government targets can seed an industry, but they can also inflate a bubble, counting concert receipts toward a GDP goal while the underlying pipeline stays thin.¹ A skeptic would say Vietnam has manufactured demand faster than it has built the machine to sustain it, and that the gap is where the story breaks.²

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY THIS

The thesis is not "Vietnam is the next Korea." It is "Vietnam is running Korea's cultural-export playbook as deliberate state policy, at unprecedented speed." That claim dies if the concert economy proves a two-summer spike that never hardens into a system — if the survival-show seasons keep decaying, if no durable label-and-management infrastructure grows underneath, and if the export never materialises beyond Vietnamese-diaspora audiences. Watch three things: whether a Vietnamese act charts or tours meaningfully *outside* Vietnam; whether the fandoms professionalise into a standing industry rather than a seasonal fever; and whether the state target survives contact with a bad year. If those move, the machine is real. If they don't, this was a manufactured fad with a GDP line attached.³

So what is the takeaway? A forecast tight enough to grade on this magazine's own scoreboard. Before the

year is out, one of the big Western titles — the same ones that flogged Blackpink-in-Hanoi and the chip-factory boom — files the piece it has so far walked past: not a concert review but the *industrial* one, Vietnam building a state-backed idol economy on borrowed formats, and reaching, as this page did, for the Korea analogy.² If it does, note where it appeared first. If it does not, and the whole thing fades to a Vietnamese-language footnote by year's end, grade the call a miss and move on. What makes the wager plausible is Vietnam's own record in everything else it has industrialised — textiles, then electronics, then chips — a country that has repeatedly taken a low-margin process the region assumed it would only assemble and turned it into a sector it owns.⁴

The next regional culture power may be assembling itself in public, two hours north — on borrowed formats and a government's balance sheet.

The durable point under the ticket sales is what to carry away. Soft power is usually told as something that happens to a country — an accident of talent, a lucky export, a band that breaks. Vietnam is treating it as something a state can *build*, on a schedule, the way it built its factories: pick the sector, subsidise the on-ramp, manufacture the demand, and count the receipts. It may not work; the plumbing may never catch the spectacle. But the attempt itself is the news — a country deciding that culture is infrastructure, and that idols, like semiconductors, are a thing you can choose to make. A foreign desk will land on that framing soon enough. This page got there first.

SOURCES 1 The bear case — reality-format novelty decay (Season 2 wobble); Korea's 20-year label/management foundation absent; state targets can seed or inflate; scalping/site-crashes as ambiguous signals — desk analysis on reported figures (see p25–26). 2 Under-the-radar check — coverage of Vietnam's idol economy concentrated in Vietnamese state/trade press (VOV, VietnamNet, VIR, VnExpress), Korea media reporting on Vietnam, and RMIT Vietnam; no NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT/Economist feature on the state-backed idol-economy framing located (Aug 2026) — search across major Western outlets; passes the under-the-radar test (can't prove a negative absolutely — flagged). 3 Falsifier — whether a Vietnamese act charts/tours outside Vietnam, whether fandoms professionalise into a standing industry, and whether the state target survives a bad year — the desk's own test. 4 Vietnam's industrialisation arc (textiles → electronics → semiconductors) as the precedent for turning an assembled process into an owned sector — general economic reporting. Argument is the desk's; facts attributed and, where unverifiable, flagged; primary Vietnamese sources egress-blocked and gathered via search summaries.

THE LAST WORD

A whole book of things that refuse to be rushed. Beer that takes three weeks and still costs more than the shop; an Edo road you cross on your own feet; muscle you have to earn back from a drug that took it; a child you reach by knowing, not by locking; a country trying to grow in two years the industry another took twenty to build. The fast way was on offer on every page. What made the shortcut tempting is exactly what made it thin — and the things worth having, this week as most weeks, went the long way round.

THIS ISSUE'S DESKS

The World · Singapore · Property · Technology · The Kit · The Good Life · Screen & Sound · The Family Desk · The Macro Desk ·
The Rabbit Hole · Fitness · The Travel Desk · The Diary · The Long Read

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